PITCH DECKS

The Ultimate Guide to Pitch Decks for Enterpreneurs

(The 2021 Edition)

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Introduction

Pitch decks have become synonymous with startups and raising capital in recent years. If you are starting a new business of any type or are planning to pivot or grow an existing one, you need a pitch deck.

There are many misconceptions about pitch decks, what should be in them, how they are used, and also the best business templates sites to find them to get started. Check out this guide to creating a great deck that fuels all of your goals.

Put simply, a pitch deck is a group of slides, organized in a presentation. They are typically used to facilitate and support fundraising efforts for startups prior to going public or an exit.

A pitch deck is used to explain your business, it's strengths and the opportunity for those who get involved.

A pitch deck is *not* an in depth business plan or detailed breakdown of everything about your business and how the technology works. It *is* a tool for simplifying the description of the business and a sales tool.

Pitch decks have been most commonly created in Microsoft PowerPoint in the past. Yet, there are many new tools available. This can include new slide building and presentation tools and graph and financial modeling software.

It is important not to get too complicated. A pitch deck is all about simplifying and streamlining. You will likely have multiple people collaborating on creating your pitch deck from inside and outside of your organization. You'll need to be able to easily and efficiently share your pitch deck and multiple

drafts and variations with multiple people. This will include advisers and coaches and potential investors.

You may find something like Google Drive ideal for optimizing this entire process. As well as finding a proven existing pitch deck template and plug in your data, instead of trying to reinvent the wheel.

While you may ultimately publish your pitch deck on various online platforms, and directly send it out via email or other direct messages, as well as presenting it on screen in person, hosting it online can be one of the most efficient.

This way you can give and revoke access instantly as desired, update your pitch deck in real time and customize it to new audiences, and avoid issues with large attachments, or losing it.

Your pitch deck will always be evolving. You'll need one at every round of fundraising. You'll be continually updating it during rounds and between them. Even when it comes time to shop and sell your company you'll be using some variation of this as a pitch book.

Contrary to some misconceptions you aren't going to just get by without a pitch deck. Neither can you just expect your pitch deck to do everything for you. Even if you have fabulous relationships with partners at VC firms who want to invest, they'll need the deck to present to their partners and as part of their process and due diligence for their investors. In the reverse, you can have the best deck in the world, but still need to be able to present verbally and to field questions from investors.

In fact, today a pitch deck can also play a significant role as a form of business plan and as a recruiting tool for key team members and advisors. You'll even use it to communicate your company to outsourced workers.

Chapter 1

A Business Plan or a Pitch Deck

Which should you be focusing on first as a startup founder, a business plan or pitch deck?

For decades entrepreneurs and business owners believed they needed to focus on building a comprehensive business plan. All before taking real action. There were good reasons for that. More recently, many entrepreneurs have gone almost exclusively with pitch decks in place of a traditional business plan.

Which of these two approaches is best? Does it depend on the type of business you are starting or if you plan any fundraising efforts? Is a hybrid approach the wisest move? Or should you stay intensely focused on one before the other?

Definitions: Business Plans Vs. Pitch Decks

A traditional business plan is a fairly lengthy text based document. It lays out all of the parts of the business. From the corporate structure to marketing plans to startup needs and growth plans and financial forecasts for the next five years. Plus the much longer term game plan. This is typically in a Microsoft Word style format, and can easily run 25 pages. It begins with a brief executive summary. Which can be 1-3 pages long on its own.

A pitch deck is a slide based presentation. Think PowerPoint or Google Slides formatting. Ideally your pitch deck will run

between 5 to 20 slides. It is a very short, simple and compact version of a traditional business plan. Pitch decks emerged specifically for pitching startups to potential investors for fundraising. However, they are increasingly replacing business plans.

Uses For A Business Plan Today

Are business plans still relevant today?

Yes and no. Every business and entrepreneur should have a plan. We all know what failing to plan means. Yet, what is effective and valuable in terms of business plans may be changing and evolving.

A business plan really helps you get depth and length in your plans. It gives more clarity than you could ever fit into a pitch deck. This process helps entrepreneurs really think through the details and big vision and long term game plan. It helps you get granular with marketing plans, startup costs, cash flow needs, and financial projections.

It also helps to give you a framework to start building on. As well as really thinking through a functional business model.

Investors, advisors and other key players may be completely satisfied with seeing a one page business plan, executive summary and bullet pointed action plan. Providing that accompanies a great pitch deck.

However, there may still be some scenarios in which you will be asked for your business plan. This includes applying for some types of loans, leasing space and joining certain groups or applying for licenses.

The Pros & Cons Of Business Plans Today

The advantages:

- Being forced to think through the details
- Having an in depth plan and awareness of your real needs
- Being able to back up the hype with something tangible
- Credibility with potential partners and early investors
- Being prepared if you are asked for it
- Having a comprehensive guide and roadmap to follow

The cons:

- Chances are no one else will ever read it
- Things move so fast, most may be irrelevant in a couple of months
- It's a blackhole for your time, energy and momentum
- Many entrepreneurs get bogged down here and miss their best opportunities
- Additional expenses with negligible returns
- Appearing like a novice to experienced investors

Uses For A Pitch Deck Today

A pitch deck is for more than just fundraising.

Pitch decks are synonymous with startup fundraising. Yet, they shouldn't be exclusively tied to fundraising activities or only when you are out there actively raising for a round.

In fact, you'll find pitch decks useful from before day one through your exit.

These scenarios include:

- Honing your initial concept and model, like with a business plan
- Gaining initial feedback
- Recruiting cofounders
- Enrolling advisors

- Hiring early and key team members
- Pitching investors on and offline
- Securing early customers and strategic partnerships
- Through multiple fundraising round
- Getting to an exit

The Pros & Cons Of Pitch Decks Today

The advantages:

- Expected when raising capital
- A streamlined framework for creating a mini business plan
- Easily and efficiently updated for multiple purposes and over time
- Much faster to create
- More likely that you will use and refer to it often
- Easier to share
- Enables you to get down to business faster

The cons:

- Can be an excuse not to have a real plan of model
- Dangerous gaps from not thinking through the details
- Not prepared when a business plan is requested
- Emphasis on fluff and hype versus substance
- Very short term outlook

Summary

There are many advantages and disadvantages of solely running on a traditional business plan or new modern pitch deck. Trying to juggle both simultaneously can further compound the cons, distraction and length of time before you really get into the game.

Today, it seems the best prepared entrepreneurs, especially

when it comes to getting funded are those with a strong pitch deck, and at least a one page business plan, and strong executive summary.

Do not dismiss the importance and value of having a real plan. You could be sabotaging your own mission and future. If you plan to stay a small local business or solopreneur forever a real business plan is smart. Though as the founder of a fast moving startup which needs funding, a pitch deck can be even more important. You'll probably be moving so fast your business plan will never keep up.

If you have to choose one, it should be focusing on knocking out a winning pitch deck. This process will also give you many of the answers and framework for fleshing out your real business plan. At least this way you'll be poised to raise money, and build out your team and gain early clients in the meantime.

Chapter 2

Slides you need in a pitch deck

Ready to raise millions of dollars for your next startup fundraising round? Is your pitch deck fundable?

You may be wondering what are the slides you need in your pitch deck?
Below is an in-depth commentary on a pitch deck template that I put together some time ago. It includes the slides you need in your pitch deck and that are necessary to pass the pitch test with potential investors and get the money you need to take your business to the next level.

Here is a quick summary of what those slides are:

1. Cover
2. Concept
3. Problem
4. Solution
5. Market Size
6. Competition
7. Competitive Advantage
8. Product
9. Customers
10. Traction
11. Business Model
12. Financials
13. Other Investors
14. Team
15. Advisors
16. Use of Funds
17. Back Cover

Here are the slides you'll need to pass the pitch test with potential investors and get the money you need to take your business to the next level…

1. Cover Slide

First impressions are everything. This is especially true when it comes to pitch decks and asking for investment. This is your most important slide. Consider that even if you have an existing startup and have raised before, even a 20 page pitch deck can be a little long for the average investor's attention span. If you're only asking for $20M, then each page is worth a million dollars. You cover is probably worth a lot more than that. If it isn't awesome, no one is going to look at the next slide. Nail it and you'll have a huge advantage over 99% of your competing startups.

This slide needs to show clearly what is the company and perhaps insert some of the contact details of the CEO like email or telephone number. This way potential investors know where to reach you in the event there is further interest.

Having a nice high-resolution image as the cover of the pitch deck definitely helps. You may use a plain logo or include as well an image on the background. Note that people tend to associate memories to images and for that reason, you want to have the investor remembering your pitch deck easily by including a powerful image.

2. The Concept

What is your startup idea all about? This is a good slide to make an impact. Think about including a powerful image and tagline.

3. What's The Problem?

What is the big and urgent problem that your business is

trying to solve? What do they have to believe to buy-in to your mission? What storytelling examples can you give?

The problem needs to be very clear and to the point. This is your chance to connect with the investor and to have them relate in a certain way with what you are doing.

When an investor gets involved with your venture is either because of one of the following things:

- They have experienced the same problem in the past
- There is a clear sense of ROI down the line for them
- Given their professional expertise they understand it (e.g. doctors with healthcare)

If an investor falls inside the three buckets of interest cited above at the same time, that means you got your lead investor. This may result in you securing at least 20% of the financing of the entire round that you are looking to raise.

When you are pitching in person you want to tell them the story of how you came across this problem. I see this often on the guests that I interview on the DealMakers Podcast where some of the most successful entrepreneurs share how they did it.

4. The Solution

How is your startup solving the big problem? What's your vision and grand strategy? The tactics may change, but the idea should resonate as making sense.

Keep in mind the solution needs to be just one. Not three or four, especially if you are an early-stage startup. The last thing you want is the investor thinking that you are all over the place without focus.

On this slide, you want to come across as clear and as concise

as possible. Perhaps a good image of the product in action is a good combination with some text in order to make a good impression.

Avoid statements referencing you being the only one doing this, you being the clear leader, etc. There are at least 100 people that have come up with that idea before you and other companies that may be tackling that same problem with a different approach.

If you are presenting in person I would recommend doing a demo of the product LIVE. Much more powerful than walking them through a slide. This way they will get it right away.

The problem and solution are slides you need in your pitch deck with a proper flow. The solution needs to come after your problem slide with a bang.

5. Market Size

How big is this space? How big is projected to get? What is your potential share of this market. If your numbers aren't in the billions you probably need to think bigger.

The market size is critical as it will also determine the potential returns for the investor down the line. Probably one of the most important slides you need in your pitch deck. If you have the best product and the best time with a small market nothing matters. Too much risk for little reward.

Also, it is critical here to show growth. The last thing you want is to have the investor thinking that your market has touched the peak. For this reason, you want to project how the market will be growing over the course of the next 5 to 10 years.

6. The Competition

Yes, you have competition. Even if you think you are creating a

new market, there are potential competitors. Be sure you have done your research well here, or you will fall flat on your face hard.

This is one of the slides you need in your pitch showcased via a diagram like the one showing above. This, in essence, is a good idea to show the investor the competitors that you have executed in your space. How you compare to them and where you land with your value proposition. A good resource to find potential competitors is Crucnhbase where you can search by sector or even keywords related to your business.

As shown on this slide you want to clearly differentiate yourself from the rest so that the person that is reviewing the slide gets what makes your company so unique.

As you can find your logo needs to be on the top right-hand side. From a psychology perspective that is where the eye tends to go when looking at a new slide. You want to make sure that your logo stands out from other competitors.

Perhaps another slide that you want to include is one that describes how much capital each competitor has already raised in the past and at what valuation. This could help in providing some perspective of how much the market is paying. This could play in your favor when the time comes to negotiate the terms of the deal or proceeding with a potential investment.

7. Competitive Advantages

Even Uber has serious competitors. Compare how you will stand out against the competition, or even become an attractive partner or acquisition prospect for them.

As part of the slides you need in your pitch deck, on this slide, you want to talk about the advantages of your business and product. Some of the things you can include might be patents and other defensive IP, distribution channels that you have,

partners, etc.

Basically what you want to communicate is why you have such a unique position within your industry that sets you as one of the leaders.

The best way to present this is with bullet points. You can also display some of the logos of your partners in the event your advantage is on distribution channels via business development deals.

8. Your Product

What is your product or service? You may even want to add screenshots to show it off.

To make it even more powerful you may want to add some description about the product itself and some quotes of some of your existing clients talking about how much they love your product.

As mentioned above you could also do a demo of the product to everyone in the room if you are doing this in person. This is obviously one of the slides you need in your pitch deck but if you are in person you can take it away and bake it into your narrative.

9. Customers

Who are your customers exactly? Are they enterprise level, B2B or B2C? What is their profile? What are their use cases?

What is the feedback you've already received from potential customers and paying users? What is the press and others saying about your startup?

Here are well you could go as far as mentioning some of the metrics and historical data that you have been able to gather

from your own customers. From the slides you need in your pitch deck this one will give some insights to the investor on how well you are tracking and measuring success.

Here are a few ideas:

- How long do they stay in your platform
- What are the numbers around repeating customers
- What is the customer profile (age, location, etc)
- Customer acquisition cost
- The lifetime value of your customer

10. Traction

What traction have you accumulated so far? What is expected by investors will vary by funding round. It's best to focus on fewer or one main metric to keep it simple and maintain momentum. It could be users, sales or profits.

This slide is probably the most important of the slides you need in your pitch deck because it shows validation. When it comes to the traction it can be presented in different ways. Depending on the business traction could be in the form of registered users, acquisition strategy, user retention, or revenue growth month over month.

From my perspective, the most powerful way to show traction is by showing a slide that displays how great you have been performing month over month in terms of revenue.
If you can show at least over 10% growth each month that is a good data point to share. Accelerator like YC require 15% growth week over week but that may be a bit aggressive.

If you are still pre-revenue then you want to explore another metric that shows progress and that would get prospect investors excited. Some metrics in this regard could be customer acquisition growth, retention, etc.

11. Business Model

What is your business model? How will you acquire customers? How will you make money?

Out of the slides you need in your pitch deck, in the business model you want to explain how you are making money from your operational structure. Depending on the industry in which you are operating you may want to go in detail into what are your margins and how much it costs you to acquire your customers.

12. Financials

What does your accounting look like? Are you making money? Are you profitable? Do you still have a sizable amount of cash in the bank from a recent round?

Hands down this is the #1 most important piece of information from the slides you need in your pitch deck. Investors spend over 23% of the review time on this single slide so you want to clearly describe your numbers.

Normally you want to shoot for at least 3 years of projections. There are some institutional investors that even ask for 5 years of projections.

Even though projections are a shot in the dark when you are dealing with startups, they do provide a good idea of where the business is heading and potential outcomes. It also gives a good idea to the investor as to how grounded the management of the company is.

This slide is more important than entrepreneurs normally think. When you first connect with an institutional investor they will ask for your pitch deck. 3 months later they will ask you at your next meeting where things are at and then they will make a decision. With this in mind, it is always a good

idea to be more on the conservative side and to over-deliver. The worst thing that can happen is for you to completely miss the mark and under deliver..

Additionally, you will need to have ready your financials in Excel format as investors may want to see that after reviewing your pitch deck. For that reason, you do not need to go into much detail on the deck. All you need is to provide a summary.

If you are an early stage startup you may get away without having a financial slide at all. If you do include one, expect investors to spend the bulk of their time on this one slide. So, make sure you've checked your math. Make your projections appealing, but there has to be some rationale for your big claims.

13. Other Investors

What other investors have participated in previous fundraising rounds or have pledged to participate or lead this round?

From the slides you need in your pitch deck this is what I call the social proof slide. Here you want to add existing investors that could serve as social proof for prospects.

Some of the people reviewing the presentation may already know one of your existing investors. For that reason, it is good to have them included as it ultimately increases your chances of getting funded. You'd be surprised by how small the world is. Everyone knows each other. Especially in the venture world.

Moreover, it is key that you don't place one specific amount on the slide. As shown on this slide you will be able to find a range.

For example, if you place just $5M then funds that invest up to $3M will not look at your deal. The same would happen if you were to leave just the number $3M. By saying that you are only

raising $3M then all the funds that are only investing up north of $4 or $5M will not look at your opportunity.

For the reason stated above by adding a range you get to include everyone and as a result, you will increase your chances of receiving investment as your funnel of prospects is much wider.

14. The Team

Along with your cover and financials, this is one of your three most important pitch deck slides. As an early stage startup your team is the number one thing investors are evaluating. It's the make or break for investing in you. Invest in making this slide great.

Instead of putting the entire team, by including your most junior people, I would only have on this slide the key people in the company. This could be the founders and other senior folks that are running the company with you within the management team.

Startups move very fast and the junior people tend to switch working places too fast. Especially millennials. It is not a good idea to have investors review your presentation and then three months later have them see people changing in your organization. Investors could interpret that things are not working for the business reason why employees are leaving.

Also, do not put the entire bios of the management team. I would recommend putting a few important bullets on each member. This could be companies they worked at before your startup and perhaps some impressive accomplishments (e.g. NYT Bestselling Author, serial entrepreneur, 3 major exits, etc).

15. Advisors

These are the folks you have brought on to help guide you in

the right direction. Make sure that you are stating clearly what is the expertise they are bringing to the table. This is another slide that provides social proof from the slides you need in your pitch deck.

Your advisors will be changing as the company matures. In the beginning, the type of advisors you want is the celebrity type, the very successful people that would make you look good, etc. However, when you are a little bit more mature in the lifecycle of the company you want people that would be very much involved with your strategy providing guidance.

Advisors are also a great way to receive introductions to other investors. They serve as well as social proof to show others that you have respected and accomplished individuals helping you out to push things forward. Essentially you are communicating you are not just a random person with a random idea.

16. Use Of Funds

What are you going to do with any money you receive in this round? Why is it needed? Or is this round more about recruiting great stakeholders to get you to the next level?

Out of the slides you need in your pitch deck this will tell investors how well you have done your homework. You definitely want to get this slide right. Before having this slide created, put together an outline of your 18 to 24-month plan so that you have a clear understanding of how much money you will need to have in order to execute the strategy.

In the event you are not clear or miss the mark on certain things where you should be investing company resources, you will end up giving a really bad signal to prospects. Investors could have a negative interpretation thinking that you do not have a good grasp of the space. Also, investors will be left with the impression that you don't know why you are raising money.

Ultimately a company without true north is very dangerous. What are your next milestones? How will this money help you achieve them? What time frame are you estimate you will hit them in? How much of a runway will this money give you before you raise again or find an exit? Any references you have to back up your track record of hitting previous milestones will help make you look great here.

17. Back Cover & Contact Information

From the slides you need in your pitch deck this is the part where you take the time to thank the investor for reviewing your presentation. Especially for making it this far through your deck.

Repeat your contact information so that they can get in touch if they are interested in funding you, or at least setting up a meeting. Make your contact info obvious and easy. Use whatever channel is easiest for them, and which you'll be on top of responding to fast.

Other information that would definitely help to beef up this section is press mentions. Some quotes from articles in which you were mentioned could be nice to have here. Have such quotes included with the logo of the media publication in which you were featured.

Summary

Your entire business idea and future can all ride on the power of your pitch deck. These are the most important slides to include, and what to make sure you get on them.

Don't let this step bog you down, but for how vital success is here, it's worth investing in making your slides great or getting some feedback from a fundraising consultant, before you blow any pitching opportunities.

Chapter 3

How long it takes to create a pitch deck

How long does it really take to create a pitch deck that will get your startup funded?

You've only got one shot to pitch investors and wow them with your deck. Is your up to the job? If not, how long is it going to take to craft an effective one so that you can start pitching?

Timing Is Critical

Timing is critical for startups. That's even truer when it comes to product launches and fundraising campaigns.

You need to have a great handle on the time it will take to create your pitch deck and other fundraising campaign materials in order to survive and get funded.

You need to know your timeline so that you can begin leading up to your pitch and pre-marketing any campaigns, and dripping the hype and PR to prime investors for them. Some may have to buckle up are prepare for a challening year of fundraising campaigning, even after they have a great deck in hand. Others may be under the gun to get money in ASAP and hit the ground running beofre they run out of time and money to work on this startup.

So, how long should you plan for it to take to create a pitch deck? What are some of the hacks to get it done faster? What are some of the gotchas that could take a lot longer than you expect?

How Long It Takes To Make A Pitch Deck

How long can it possibly take to throw together a handful or a dozen slides?

The quick answer is that is can take as little as a few hours to well over a month.

A pich deck pro armed with all the relevant data can probably whip up a powerful deck in less than a day of work. Though in most cases, from scratch to polish, startup entrepreneurs should plan weeks to complete a fundable deck they are willing to bet their business idea on.

2 Hacks For Creating A Pitch Deck Faster

1. Use A Proven Template

Save reinventing the wheel and dsisruption for your product. Being too creative with your deck is just going to confuse investors and be a roadblock to successful funding. Don't take the scenic route to creating a slide presentation from scratch either. There is too much else you need to do, and time is of the essence. Use a proven existing pitch deck template, and customize it with your data and style.

2. Hire A Pitch Deck Pro

You could spend months just learning about what to put in your deck, the slides to include, current trends on what is getting funded and what investors want to see, as well as formats. You can't afford that. Bring in someone specifically to work on your deck. Someone who does this type of work for a living. They can do it in 100th of the time it will take you. No matter what they charge by the hour, it will be less than you will spend of your own time trying to figure it all out.

Steps To Creating A Winning Pitch Deck

Recruiting & Hiring Help

Use freelance experts to help complete a winning deck fast. You'll need:

- Designers
- Image/video editors
- Researchers
- Copywriters
- Strategists and funraising experts

This process can take anywhere from 1 day to 3 weeks depending on how you do it. Hopefully you already have some good fundraising advisors you can reach out to. Then use platforms like UpWork to reach out to top talent in this space and hire fast.

Build Your Target List Of Investors

Look up and create a short list of potential investors that you will tailor this pitch deck towards. Knowing the type of investor and the theme of what they are investing in will make a lot of difference in pitching well.

If you are behind the game on this, you may need 1-2 weeks to really identify, filter and create a tight list.

Like most of the other tasks on this list, it's not that you'll be spending 80-100 hours a week on this one step, but you have so much else to do. If you get in a few hours today, and then finish next week, you are already 2 weeks in. Especially if you are working with assistants who may be in different time zones, and you are lagging a day between messages each way.

Research

Allow up to another 2 weeks for some serious research and compiling all the data you need to fill in your pitch deck.

This includes:

- Market size
- Market trends and direction
- Verifying the problem
- Marketing strategies
- Costs and profit margins

Images & Editing

Between creating a logo, product screenshots, modeling prototypes, or images of use cases for your product and editin team headshots allow another 2-4 weeks.

Developing The Copy

The words you use in your pitch deck will make all the difference. Each word can add or lose another million dollars in your raise.

A great copywriter who knows how to tell the right story, and can boil it down to one liners and bullet points can be an invaluable asset.

They might be able to craft all the text you need in just one day, but the best writers will already be booked up for 2-4 weeks in advance.

Reviewing & Tweaking Your Pitch Deck

Once you have it altogether test the feedback from advisors and others you trust. Allow another 1-2 weeks to compile this feedback and make adjustments before it is polished and ready to use live.

Chapter 4

Scenarios where a pitch deck is important

In what situations is a pitch deck a valuable asset?

There are many situations in which you will find a pitch deck a great asset. Fundraising may be the most obvious. Though if you wait until you and your startup is ready to raise a round you may be seriously selling yourself and company short.

Check out these scenarios in which being equipped with a pitch deck can be extremely helpful and yield great returns.

Honing Your Startup Business Idea

One of the best uses of a pitch deck is for yourself and in the initial stages of fleshing out and polishing your vision and business idea. Especially when you are wondering what is a business model.

It's far more effective than a napkin. It's far faster and more efficient than trying to build out a voluminous business plan, only to end up making endless changes and creating a more usable pitch deck in the end anyway.

Grab a proven pitch deck template and take some time out to fill it out.

This will help you really think through your idea upfront, think about how you'll explain it to others, find a viable business model, and identify what you need to focus your energy on.

This is also the ideal time to show your pitch deck to others and get some initial feedback and advice, so that you can make adjustments to your pitch and model before rushing in or blasting it out to investors.

Enrolling Advisors

Your pitch deck is an excellent tool for connecting with advisors early on. No matter how experienced you are and what you've accomplished before, there is always benefit in bringing in targeted advisors for a startup.

Look for those with relevant experience, who can fill in some of the expertise gaps you or your founding team may be missing, and who know the investors you will be targeting for this venture and any upcoming fundraising rounds.

Making these moves early also enables you to then add these advisors to your pitch deck and make it even more powerful for whatever you use it for next.

Recruiting Cofounders

Solo entrepreneurs can create fantastic businesses. Yet, it is no secret that investors definitely prefer funding multi-founder startups. You don't want too many. That can make things a lot harder in other ways. However, two or three cofounders together can make the journey much easier and more bearable and enjoyable. In addition to improving your odds of getting funded, it dramatically increases the odds you'll keep going when things are tough. It can also take the financial pressure off if you can bring in cofounders who will contribute capital, or who will at least be willing to temporarily forego a paycheck when needed and take stock options. Their ownership mindset can also make them some of your best workers and ambassadors. Far more so than any salary or perks can buy. You'll get a lot farther with attracting and convincing cofounders if you have a clean, organized and well thought

through initial pitch deck.

Recruiting Team Members

You can also use your pitch deck to recruit early and key team members. It is going to be the company with the best team who wins. In fact, a strong team alone can add immense tangible value to your business and justify a sizable acquisition.

Serious talent is going to be cautious about who they join. Especially with so many other options on the table. They want to know you are serious, organized and have a plan that is going to work. A nice clean pitch deck is the easiest and fastest way to demonstrate this and why they should jump on board.

Securing Early Customers

One of the most underutilized, but most powerful and valuable uses of a pitch deck is to secure early customers.

You can approach this in several ways. You can do it subconsciously and subtly by approaching key decision makers for their advice and feedback. Seed the idea of becoming an early adopter. You can survey them and ask for their input on honing your solution for their needs.

When this leads to pre-orders and advance contracts you are ensuring you have cash coming in and there is at least some demand. Just ensure you are bringing in actual money, not just getting vague nods to doing business with you in the future. There is a huge difference.

Some of those who have done this successfully have even found these first customers become inbound investors who fund the development and building of the product and hiring the team needed. Some of these partners may even provide some of the other resources you need to really get live and in the game.

In Place Of A Business Plan

Even though many hot startups seem to have proven they can get away without a traditional plan, there can still be a variety of scenarios in which a business plan is asked for.

Some of the most common can include:

- Applying for business loans
- Getting commercial real estate loans
- Securing leases for space and equipment
- Applying for various licenses

It's still smart to have a business plan. At least a very strong executive summary, and a one page plan. However, far too many would be entrepreneurs end up wasting an enormous amount of time and energy on business plans they never really use. It often costs them first mover advantage, credibility, millions in potential capital and sometimes the entire opportunity.

Startup Fundraising

Whether you are raising a friends and family pre-seed round or a Series C, you don't want to be caught without a strong pitch deck. It will make all the difference in getting the capital and investment partners your venture needs, even if you already have personal relationships and a strong network.

The Exit

When it comes to really planning and shopping for an exit you'll want a pitch book and information memorandum. However, you can certainly begin with your updated pitch deck. It's similar, and the chances are high that you may be running two potential processes at once. Or you may ultimately find your exit and acquirer while running a fundraising process.

Chapter 5

What is the best font for a pitch deck?

So much rides on the power and effectiveness of your pitch deck as a startup that even factors like which font you use can make or break you.

Factors like font may not only directly determine whether your pitch deck is viewed, but how much investors think your startup is worth, how much capital they are willing to bet on you and on what terms, but if they are even able to follow through and send you the funds you really want and need.

If there are four main elements of your deck (content, delivery, images, and text), then the font may carry 25% of the value of your pitch deck. If you are pushing for an aggressive Series A round, your font choice could be worth $25M. You don't want to get bogged down in tiny details instead of just executing and getting things done, but with so much on the line, even the entire future of your venture, it is worth getting this right.

What is the best font for your startup's pitch deck? The font affects how investors view your startup and worth, and the capital they'll invest.

What Is A Font?

A font is a style of text.

There are probably far more styles of font that you knew existed. More are being created over time.

PC World reports that there are almost 70 font choices in the home and student version of Microsoft Word. While the professional version offers 216.

Google Docs offers even more. According to Wikipedia, Google offers 1023 font choices.

Some of the most common fonts include:

- Arial
- Times New Roman
- Helvetica
- Verdana

Some have definitely stood the test of time and have been around for almost 100 years. Others are more modern and have become popular online. So, what is the best font for your startup's pitch deck?

Fonts: Guiding Principles & Best Practices

The best way to think about fonts for your pitch deck is with the same guiding principles governing your whole presentation.

That is to keep it clean and simple.

This is the first rule and question to ask yourself and your team when you are considering any font for your deck. It is clean and simple?

These are some of the other considerations and questions to ask when evaluating fonts when fundraising.

Is It Easy To Understand?

Your font must pass this test. If it is not easy to read potential investors and customers are going to have a hard time making

sense of it, or finding you. Some fonts may look smart as a logo, but the letters are too hard to make out for anyone outside of your company who doesn't already know what it is supposed to say.

This is a complete fail. You may have everything else perfect, but if they can't email you or find you online to send you a check or wire you money, that is a pretty expensive blunder.

Of course, if investors are struggling so will customers, and that's already a nail in the coffin on your business. Keep that in mind when figuring out what is the best font for your startup's pitch deck?

Is It Commonly Used By Your Team Members?

While there are over 1,000 fonts you can pick from or download and add to your favorite slide creation software, few may be regularly used by your team members.

Do they have the font? Do they like working with it? Do they even have access to it if they are working remotely in another country?

Using a more common font will help streamline everything, including any iterations and updates to your deck as you go.

Branding

Does the font match your brand? What does your chosen font say about your brand?

Does it match your logo, stated customer base, and the type of investor who would be a part of a mission like the one you are on?

It should feel elegant or sophisticated if you are in the luxury market. It should be clean and serious if you are in enterprise

technology, and so on.

Put yourself in the investors' shoes. What do they see? What is it most like for them? Does it look like a highly successful startup's font? One that they are used to and want to replicate the success of?

What To Avoid When Selecting A Font For Your Pitch Deck

Avoid 'fantasy' style fonts. They can cheapen your brand, look unprofessional and are harder to read.

The same applies to cursive, script and italic style fonts and serif style fonts.

Avoid fad and trendy fonts. Hopefully you are creating a business that can last at least 10 years. Not one that is going to go bust when Google changes is algorithms again next month.

Other Factors To Consider When Designing Your Pitch Deck

How Many Fonts Should You Use?

Use no more than 1-3 fonts in your pitch deck. You can highlight different lines of text with different font sizes, colors and shading, or bold text formatting instead. Yes, figuring out what is the best font for your startup's pitch deck is a process that you want to work out carefully.

Font Size

Guy Kawasaki has recommended that all text should be at least 30 point font size in a pitch deck. Your headers and sub headers should be even larger.

Colors

Make sure your text color choices are strategic as well. Do they

match your brand, and the type of startup that investors will expect to perform well, and have the ability to deliver 100x returns?

The Amount of Text Used In Your Deck

Only use the bare minimum amount of text absolutely vital to getting the main points across and answering the most basic questions investors will have.

Chapter 6

Do's and don'ts when creating pitch deck

What are the do's and don'ts of creating a pitch deck for your startup?

What should and shouldn't you do when creating a pitch deck to ensure it is effective and maximizes your odds of getting the funding you need?

The Power Of Pitch Decks

Pitch decks are an incredibly important piece of the puzzle for startups. Yours can make all the difference in getting off the ground, maintaining the funds you need to keep surviving and thriving, and whether you can really unleash the potential this business idea has, or not.

You really only get one shot at making a first impression with your pitch deck. If you blow it, you have probably blown your chance of funding from that investor. If you nail it, that successful connection can lead to many more pitches and opportunities.

Even beyond the present fundraising round, your pitch deck can be very influential when it comes to recruiting the best advisors, partners, and key team players.

With so much on the line, it is worth investing the time and energy to get it right. Let's get started exploring the do's and don'ts of creating a pitch deck for your startup.

The Do's Of Creating A Winning Pitch Deck

There are volumes of amateur and outdated advice on pitch decks out there today. It is a hot topic many people want to cash in on. Unfortunately, that can make knowing what to do really confusing too.

Here are some of the most important things you do want to do when it comes to creating your own deck.

Keep It Super Clean & Simple

Simplicity is your friend and white space is your ally.

If in doubt, leave it out. It is better to have more empty space so that viewers can absorb the most important points, and don't gloss over or get bored before the call to action.

Use images and graphics where it makes sense. As they say, a picture is worth a thousand words.

For more information about how media works, check out this video that explains the key mistakes to avoid when creating your pitch deck.

Focus On Your Four Most Important Slides

There is a lot more that goes into crafting a powerful pitch deck than most realize. In fact, it can sometimes seem a lot harder to create a very simple looking deck than to just brain dump everything you've got in slide form. Between research and design each slide can be more demanding than you anticipate. So, make sure you put the most energy and thought into the four slides that are most pivotal and important for investors.

These are:

- Cover slide: it's all about first impressions, and getting

them to keep swiping
- Problem slide: demonstrate clarity on the problem, and how big it is
- Financial slide: this is where investors will spend most of their time
- Team slide: the team is even more important than your startup idea

Show Your Traction

Millions of people can talk a good game when it comes to selling and presenting. Very, very few can really execute. What can you prove that you can actually do?

Show the progress you've been making, the milestones you've achieved and the growth you've maintained.

Show What You'll Use The Money For

If they are interested in your startup, what will you use their funds for? Put yourself in the investor's shoes. What is a worthy investment of their capital that will really yield returns? Do you still need to finance building a prototype? Do you need to hire experts to build this? Or is it scaling a proven marketing and business model? Make sure your ask lines up with these uses.

Get Feedback Before Sharing

Get third party feedback from qualified advisors before you hit send and bet everything on this deck.

Let's move on to the don'ts section of the critical do's and don'ts of creating a pitch deck for your startup.

The Don'ts Of Creating A Pitch Deck

Knowing what to do is only half of the battle. Knowing what

not to do is equally, if not even more important.

These are some of the critical don'ts when it comes to your pitch deck.

Don't Go Too Long

Shorter is better when it comes to slide count in a pitch deck. You should definitely be under 20 slides. Under 12 is even better. You might even be able to get under 10. Going too long is a huge red flag, and your slide count alone can kill your funding chances, even before they look at a single page.

Don't Provide Too Much Detail

This is not the place to take a deep dive into the details of your product, technology and all the features of your solution. They don't need to know how it all works, and typically don't want to. It will only take away from the important points and show you haven't even bothered to Google what makes a good pitch deck.

Don't Put In Anything That Requires A NDA

If you feel that you have real proprietary secrets you don't want shared, just say that, and leave out the details. Demanding a NDA from anyone you want to see your deck or who can benefit from seeing it in their work is going to dramatically shrink the pool of those who will be interested, and that usually means excluding the best talent and investors right away.

Don't Try To Reinvent The Wheel

This is not the place to reinvent, show off your innovation, disrupt and break things. That's what your business does. Don't try to reinvent the pitch deck. You'll just confuse investors. Serve it up in the format they expect. Besides, it is far

more effective and efficient to use a proven pitch deck template anyway.

Don't Forget Your Contact Info

How tragic would it be if you wow an investor with your deck and they want to fund you, but you didn't make your contact information obvious enough so they can quickly take action?

Keep these essential do's and don'ts of creating a pitch deck for your startup in mind and you're sure to get the funding you need.

Chapter 7

Deadly signs of a bad pitch deck

Is your pitch deck and fundraising campaign doomed to fail?

Fundraising can be challenging at the best of times. It's going to be a lot harder if your pitch deck isn't up to the job. Unfortunately there are a lot of bad pitch decks that get floated out there every day. How do you know if yours has a chance?

If it is displaying any of these critical red flags you need to go back to the drawing board before you try sharing and presenting it.

Asking For A NDA First

If you are asking potential investors, advisors, and hires to sign NDAs before they even see your deck you aren't going to get far. At least not with anyone serious and who is good. NDAs at this stage are a big red flag that you are a complete novice, don't have the right priorities, and your startup probably isn't going anywhere. You'll immediately be dismissed by those you really need to see it and get input from. If there is any real trade secret and secret recipe involved, then just leave those sensitive details out of the deck.

It's Ugly

Simple and basic is one thing. That might just say you are a little lazy or didn't feel it was worth investing in a good pitch deck and presentation. You might get away with it. Then there is outright ugly. If your deck is an eyesore, and others are

gently trying to tell you that you could improve on it, take a step back and put some time and money into the design.

You might be bootstrapping and running lean, but it is worth every penny and minute. Consider how much your pitch deck is worth if you successfully raise this round and your business takes off. If you really believe in your startup idea, then you have to show it, and that you respect the time and attention of prospective investors.

Your Cover Slide Lacks Key Info

First impressions count. Experienced investors are looking for an interesting cover slide that includes the core basics, like your company name and contact information.

There Are Too Many Slides

Having too many slides is another deadly sign that you aren't going to get funded. There is enough information out there telling you that shorter and sweeter is better when it comes to slide count in a pitch deck that there is really no good excuse for a lengthy deck.

If you've got more than 16 or 20 slides it is an instant sign that you haven't bothered to do the most basic homework, can't listen and take advice, and are incapable of focusing and keeping it simple. If you can't boil it down by a couple of slides, then investors can't expect you'll be able to make anything more complicated work or will make the effort. 8-12 slides is plenty.

It Looks Too Complicated & Detailed

Simple, clean and clear is the key to a successful pitch deck and getting funded. If they start swiping slides and they are cluttered, packed with text, and busy, it is an immediate turn off. Investors will immediately know that you really don't

understand how startups, fundraising and they work. If you can't get this simple thing right, they know it is probably not worth looking any further or reading all that tiny messy text or trying to make sense of your schematics.

Even if they do give you a chance, they are highly likely to quickly gloss over and either get bored, run out of time before reviewing the next deck in their inbox, or miss the good stuff.

Not Being Crystal Clear & Simple About The Problem

For startups to be successful in business and efficient enough to make it they have to be solving a strong problem, and they must have an incredible level of clarity about the problem they are solving.

It's true that your product or solution and company may be able to simultaneously solve many problems, bring many improvements to efficiency and the features can have many side benefits. The bottom line is that 99% of that is irrelevant in this context. You need to prove you are laser focused on solving one specific problem and doing it incredibly well.

Overstating Big Claims

Be optimistic, sell it, and show the big upside potential by all means. Investors want to be inspired and buy into big visions too. Just don't get carried away. Be sure your claims and stats are based on real facts, and that you can back them up with credible references.

Missing Key Data

Before you even choose a pitch deck template or hit a single key to fill it in, you should know what investors are looking for and expect in a deck. You should know the questions they are asking and the most important data points for them to be able to make a decision. Those things should be your guide to

research and formulating the deck in the first place, nothing else.

Not Acknowledging The Competition

Knowing the right things to do to build a great product and business of your own is only half of the game here. Maybe less. At least half of it is knowing and respecting the risks and threats and competition. Like a legendary boxing match, it often isn't the athlete that jumps in the ring and throws the most blows the fastest that wins the belt. It is the one that can take all that is thrown at them the longest, until the competition burns out and the perfect shot lines up.

You do have competition. Show it. There are threats. Show that you know them in your SWOT analysis.

No USP

If you have no clear USP, you have no clear business. You need to pause the deck until you've really got something with a unique value proposition, or can find someone to help draw yours out and tell the right story around it.

Chapter 8

Why the cover slide is so important in pitch decks

Why is the cover slide of your pitch deck so important?

If you see the importance, and impact it can have for good or bad, what should be on it, and how do you make the most of it?

The Science Of First Impressions

What you do up to getting your cover slide in front of potential investors for your startup is certainly vital too. You've got to make a good enough impression and be able to create enough urgency and interest to get them to even open up or click the link to your startup's pitch deck. That includes your first outreach, your subject line, you email or DM body, and even your social profile and email address.

Most investors are going to be looking at many, many decks before they even short list any of those. Even those that get a meeting will mostly hear "no." We are talking about hundreds of noes for each yes and check they write. For active investors that is a whole lot of pitch decks they need to look at. In order for them to be efficient with their time, and get down to making the deals they want to, which are going to help their own metrics and profits, they have to be very selective with their time. Even decks they like may just get 2-3 minutes of their time. That means they are likely to toss and delete a lot of pitches just based on the cover slide. Make sure yours isn't one of them.

According to the Institute for Organization Management of the US Chamber of Commerce, 55% of a first impression is visual. Next most important is the way and tone that something is said, at 38%. So, even when pitching in person, the visuals and tone is much more important than what you are saying.

According to Forbes contributor Serenity Gibbons and The Association For Psychological Science, first impressions are formed far faster than you think. Just a 10th of a second to determine traits like trustworthiness, and just 50 milliseconds to form an opinion based on a website. That may not even be long enough to fully read a tagline or the rest of the content on your cover slide.

So, when it comes to cover slides it is wise to think about the details, and psychology, and to really keep it clean and focused, so that investors pick up on the impression you really want to convey.

What Should Be On Your Pitch Deck Cover Slide?

Company Name

What does your company name say about this opportunity? What is the first impression it will give?

Tagline

This is your opportunity to sum up your business in a single sentence. This may be the best lever you have to get them to open and start swiping through the rest of your deck, or drop it in the trash folder.

Logo

The font, colors and imagery all instantly convey volumes about your startup. It is worth thinking it through from the investors' perspective. What is going to give them the first

impression that you are going to become their next hit startup, based upon what they've seen before in the market and their own portfolios?

Contact Information

Your name, business address, phone number, email address and Linkedin handle also say a lot. How can you optimism these factors for a superior first impression?

The Cover Slide & Capability

The uncomfortable truth is that ideas are cheap. They are infinite. The difference in a startup that can make it and is fundable, is that they have a strong, capable team. In milliseconds your cover slide demonstrates an enormous amount about your capability. Here are just some of those ways.

Nailing The Marketing Pitch

Make no mistake that your fundraising pitch is one of the greatest marketing tests of your business. It also directly shows how capable you are at marketing your business, brand, and product to consumers and partners. Presentation is important. So, is proving through this that you also have a great handle on the market, your target customers and the marketing you will do for acquiring customers. This shows up in your research, marketing plan, traction, marketing ROI and unit economics, as well as your fundraising ask and what you say you will do with the money.

If you haven't hired a CMO or marketing and sales talent yet, then this is a good time to at least bring in someone freelance to nail it for your pitch deck and presentation.

Coachability

While there is certainly a lot of poor and misinformation out there online, it really doesn't require a big investment to find out what really works when it comes to pitch decks and to find a proven template.

Showing up with a strong cover slide that checks the boxes shows that you are coachable, are able to seek great advice and listen. That is one of the most essential traits of entrepreneurs that have what it takes to make it, and investors want to work with.

Think about it. If you are too stubborn to do this for creating your pitch deck and presenting to them, how are they supposed to believe you'll show up in the right way when it comes to everything else.

The Cover Vs. Closing Slide

The closing slide is your chance to leave a strong impression. Use it to thank them and close with those strong elements from your cover so that they can follow through, take action and contact you.

Chapter 9

How to include an executive summary in a pitch deck

How to include an executive summary in a pitch deck?

Executive summaries have long been a critical part of starting a business and securing funding. How do they play a role in today's modern fundraising efforts? Should you even have an executive summary slide in your pitch deck? If so, what should you include on it? What other alternative ways are there to deliver this information?

What Is An Executive Summary?

As the name suggests, an executive summary sums up your business in a much shorter brief than other long form documents.

It encapsulates your ideas and business in a very fast and easy to digest format. It is everything in a nutshell, without any of the fluff.

An executive summary is critical for presenting to those who are busy and pressed on time. Even more important for those who are used to this more traditional way of pitching and funding businesses.

Often, this one document or slide will make or break everything. It will either get you deleted and banished, or it will make up investors minds to fund you, and just leave the details of how to structure that to be worked out.

They have traditionally been *the* document commercial lenders and banks have looked for. As well as more traditional investors. It is what they are used to, get and like. So, even if you are using a very modern pitch deck, don't overlook the importance and value of including an executive summary in this process.

Just don't confuse short or brief with being easy. Most startup founders find it far harder to create something short than to brain dump volumes of information and fluff into lengthy decks and business plans with many pages. It can be harder to be effective and concise.

Which is perhaps why most founders fail at fundraising. It's also why you would want to carefully understand how to include an executive summary in a pitch deck?

How To Send Your Executive Summary When Pitching Investors

Many modern pitch decks don't include an executive summary slide. Many recommendations and slide templates don't leave room for one. Especially not if you are doing a slick, short and stylish 10 or even 12 slide pitch deck.

It can already be a great struggle to condense everything to a short deck that including an executive summary slide may make that even far harder. Or you may feel that you really can't present it well and attractively with everything boiled down to one slide.

With this in mind, and to still deliver on a traditional text style executive summary you may want to separate this information from your actual slide deck. You can include a traditional summary as a 1 to 3 page Microsoft Word document as an attachment in the email you send your deck in.

Those who want to read it can. Or you can provide a link to

it in a Google Drive folder that includes other accompanying documents, like your one page business plan, investor updates, and supporting data. Work out the best way to do this when figuring out how to include an executive summary in a pitch deck?

Creating An Executive Summary Slide For Your Pitch Deck

When you are raising Series A and later rounds and have much more information to share, and investor expectations of data are higher, then your pitch deck may be a little longer. It may be 16 to 20 pages to cram it all in. This can still be pretty lengthy and time consuming to get through for busy investors.

When they are reviewing 100 or 200 decks before funding a single venture, they are super tight on time and are quick to dismiss any pitches that are slow and too drawn out, boring or uncatchy.

You may avoid getting unfairly swiped to the trash pile by leading with an executive summary slide that shows all of the key data and highlights. If you nail this, they will dig in with the intent of wanting to learn more about you and wanting to fund you. So, how do you do it?

You can accomplish this on one slide using eight icons and up to three bullets per icon. These will represent the most important slides and factors to investors and get their attention by showing you check the boxes they are looking for in an investment. It tells them the rest is worth reading.

Use these sections on your summary slide.

Context

- The problem you are solving
- The solution you are providing
- The product you are creating or selling

Mission & Goals

- What's the big vision and mission
- Where are you at
- What is the goal

Market Size

- What is the space you are tackling
- How big is the market
- How much is it growing

Competitive Analysis

- Who are your main competitors
- What is your competitive advantage
- How much better are you

Marketing Plan

- What is the go to market plan
- What are your customer acquisition costs
- How is it working so far

Financial Plan

- What are your unit economics
- What are your sales forecasts
- What are your profit forecasts

Timeline

- When did you start
- What have you achieved so far
- What's the next milestone

The Ask

- How much are you raising

- What terms are you offering
- What will you use it for

Summary

To round off how to include an executive summary in a pitch deck, this section plays a very important role in funding a business. Nailing this can make all the difference in whether the rest of your deck is even seen or not. You may use a traditional style summary in conjunction with a modern pitch deck, or work it into your pitch deck to capture attention and interest.

How to include an executive summary in a pitch deck?
Learn how to craft a robust summary for starting a business, securing funding, and convincing investors

Chapter 10

How to address the problem in a pitch deck

What is the best way to show the problem your startup is taking on in your pitch deck?

Your startup is all about solving this problem. Being able to convey it to others well may make all the difference in your ability to get funded or not. So, how should you address presenting the problem when fundraising? How do you do it incredibly well, and perhaps not only pick up some additional capital, but new ambassadors and helpers with expertise at the same time?

How Important Is The Problem?

Most entrepreneurs don't get this. They are blind to it. The problem is the most important part of not only your pitch, but your business as well.

If you get the problem right, everything else will fall inline.

You'll:

- Find the right advisors
- Hire the right people
- Secure the best investors
- Find the right solution
- Design the right products
- Roll out the best marketing
- Stick with it when things feel rough

- See your business thrive and grow
- Achieve an exit that goes on to live out the mission

With the right handle on a strong problem you'll start a business that has longevity, and can give birth to many great solutions and products. You'll see results sooner, grow faster and get a lot more out of the funds you do have. In turn that will lead to more funding, and on better terms.

This is why the problem is far more important for investors than your initially proposed solution. So, don't be afraid to take a moment to double down and dive into the problem and hone it, and even spend 50% of your time in your pitch focusing on the problem.

After all, if you don't have the problem right, then the solution is definitely wrong.

Where To Start Addressing The Problem In A Pitch Deck

Addressing the problem doesn't have to wait for your problem slide. It shouldn't.

Demonstrate clarity and focus right from the cover slide of your pitch deck with a strong tagline or slogan.

This shows them you know what you are doing right upfront, and should earn you some extra credibility, even before they start swiping through your slides. First impressions count for a lot. Don't blow yours.

The Most Important Slide In Your Pitch Deck

If the problem is the most important part of your startup and pitch, then the problem slide is the most important one in your deck.

That doesn't mean you make it complicated or squeeze five

times as much text onto this slide. In fact the opposite may be true. Keep it clean, simple and focused.

Forget all of the side problems your initial solution might help solve, or the other benefits and features. Hone in on just one main problem.

The Story

Since your slide space is so limited, your verbal pitch and presentation is where you get to talk around your slides and bullet points and really drive it home.

Begin with your story of how you encountered this problem. Images are great for conveying emotion too. Tell it in a personal story. One that your investor audience can relate to.

Describe how you then intentionally invested time and energy in exploring and verifying this problem. How you made sure it was a real problem that others were struggling with too.

Talk about how you measured it, and gauged the sense of urgency among potential customers. As well as tested the demand for and the value of a solution to this problem.

This might sound like a lot of work, but if you don't do all of this, you can't be sure about the problem. You could waste years and millions of dollars going in the wrong direction. If you can't be bothered to make this investment, why would investors bother to give you the time and capital they have worked so hard for?

Market Slide

This is where you show how big this problem is, and how much it is growing?

Use big data points. Be specific about the segment of the

market which you really plan to appeal to and can serve.

The Solution Slide

Of course, no one wants to be brought a problem without a solution for it. So, what is your intended or existing solution for this problem?

Keep it as simple as you kept your initial problem slide.

All of the details can be shared later. You can also follow up with a product and business model slide which lay it out further.

Competitive Analysis & Advantage

Your competition analysis is also a critical part of addressing the problem in your pitch deck,and gaining backing for your solution.

What other competition is out there? If there isn't much, why is that? Can that be an advantage? Who may want to create a solution for this space? How may that lead to partnerships, distribution channels, or even a grand exit?

What are existing competitors doing well or poorly? What is the void that they are leaving on the table? How are you going to do better in comparison? What is your competitive advantage?

The Team Slide

What is this best in class team that you have assembled to champion this problem? How are they uniquely experienced and skilled to do it? How committed and resilient are these people, to keep going in the face of adversity, even if this first solution attempt and product isn't perfect or has to pivot?

Chapter 11

How to position the solution in a pitch deck

How to position the solution in a pitch deck for startup fundraising?

Every slide matters in your pitch deck. This is even truer as decks get shorter and more concise. Each slide can be worth millions of dollars. So, how do you get the solution right when pitching and presenting to potential investors in your startup?

It's All About The Solution

Your startup and pitch deck is really all about your solution, right?

While there are many other things that investors will look at, evaluate you on and want to know. This business and fundraising campaign is really all about bringing your solution to life and scaling it. It's your product that you want to put out into the world.

The truth is (and experienced investors know this) that your product is probably going to change over time. It will probably change a lot. You have a lot of iterating to do to secure product market fit and make it scalable.

You may have to completely pivot in response to the market. Your solution will have to evolve significantly over time as things change, if your business is going to last for the long term too.

Plus, you'll probably be adding on more new solutions and features or upgrades and stand alone products as well.

Still, if your solution doesn't seem solid and attractive, then you aren't going to get far with fundraising or customers.

Much of it relies on positioning your solution well. So, how do you do it? And, how to position the solution in a pitch deck for startup fundraising?

Positioning Starts With Your Cover Slide

Your company name says what you do. That first impression will say a lot about your brand and value of your solution. The logo and design will tell them whether this is trying to be a luxury solution, discount solution or the hip and trendy option, and so on.

The Problem Slide

The right solution has to match the problem. This slide is used to establish the what and the need, as well as the pain level, urgency, eagerness and ability to take action to get their hands on a solution. It is your one chance, in just a few words to demonstrate your clarity on the problem and that you've verified it.

It is vital that you just pick one problem.

Your solution may have many positive side effects. After your MVP, your solution may solve several things at once, with additional benefits and cool features. Just, recognize that these are points to make another day, in another setting.

What is the one simple problem that you are going to solve?

Market Size

Your market size slide is used to show how big and widespread this problem is. How many people are going to want this solution that you are creating and you are asking these investors to bet on funding? How much will this pool of customers grow over the next 1-10 years, and beyond?

Competition Slides

Between your competition slide, SWOT analysis, and competitive advantage slides, how many others are trying to solve this same problem? Show who they are, which can help verify the problem and demonstrate the commercial potential and risks and opportunities.

How are these others doing it? What are they doing well or not? Which may subconsciously hint at potential future exit plans.

What are your competitive advantages over them? What is unique about your solution in comparison? Most importantly, how to position the solution in a pitch deck for startup fundraising?

What Is Your Solution?

On your solution slide, very simply layout what is your solution to this problem exactly, in just a few words. What is this product that specifically solves this one problem and pain point?

When presenting your pitch deck online or in person, you can tell a story around this. One that personally resonates with your audience and that they can relate to. Also include images of how people will use it.

How Are You Positioning It For Sale?

How are you pitching this solution to potential customers? Note that this may change overtime with the world, economy and marketplace.

Does it offer business cost savings they need to survive? Does it offer gains and better ROI so they can grow? Is it a must have or luxury that will appeal to their ego? What does the pricing say about the positioning?

Go Easy On The Features

Your pitch deck and presentation is just as much a test of your ability to focus and keep it simple as it is about anything else. If you lose them with too many features and bullet points, they are going to be seriously worried about your ability to run a company, go to market, and get this done.

Remember, one problem, one solution. Features are frills, and this is a no frills zone. Remember that when figuring wow to position the solution in a pitch deck for startup fundraising?

Business Model

How will you sell your solution? The method of marketing and selling has a big impact on positioning. Is it congruent with your stated positioning?

You can imagine the creator of the Birkin bag would cringe and freak out and see the end of the world coming if their bags were being resold on Craigslist.

What does it cost to make and sell this solution? What is the profit and potential return for investors? Do the unit economics make sense?

The Team

Does the team slide in your pitch deck show that you really

have what it takes to develop and sell this solution? Do they impress with the confidence they can make the best solution of this type in the industry?

You may find interesting as well our free library of business templates. There you will find every single template you will need when building and scaling your business completely for free.

How to position the solution in a pitch deck for startup fundraising? Every slide can be worth millions of dollars so pitch and present it for the most impact.

Chapter 12

How to show the target customers in a pitch deck

How to show your target customers in a pitch deck when fundraising for your startup?

Demonstrating your handle on your target customers and who they are plays a big role in fundraising. As well of course as being critical to your whole business and its longevity.

There's a lot more to showing your target customers in your deck than most realize. So, how do you do it? Where does your target market show up in addition to the target customer slide?

How to show your target customers in a pitch deck when fundraising for your startup is critical for the business and prove longevity to investors and acquirers.

The Importance Of Knowing & Showing Your Target Customers

The #1 Factor For Success

Experienced investors and entrepreneurs have gained much more appreciation for the role of the problem in startups. You can't have a good solution or strong business, without getting the problem right.

However, it is only logical that you can't get the problem right, if you don't really know and have a handle on who your customers really are.

This is where it all stems from. It is the foundation. You either have a strong one or a flawed one.

Founders need to be focused on this, and know that investors certainly will be.

Exit Potential

Investors will certainly be thinking about how this is going to lead to an exit and deliver returns for them. Who your customers are may indicate who could be good future acquirers, and how large they are. For example; are they a good match for Google, Salesforce or Facebook?

This can be especially important for strategic investors who may see a path to partnerships and mergers one day.

The Team

Demonstrating you are the right team to take on this problem is hugely important. If you are the best team, then investors will be confident you will figure everything else out, even if that means a big pivot. If you aren't the best team, then someone else will come in and dominate this space at some point.

Showing your clarity on the target customers in a pitch deck says a lot about the strength and capability of your team.

Use Of Funds

Without complete clarity on your target customers you simply cannot use any funds you raise well. Fundraising may help cover up for some of these blunders, but only if investors are willing to gamble on you still trying to figure out this core part of the idea and thesis.

Without intimately knowing and understanding your target

customers you cannot market accurately. You can't build the right branding or solution either. That can mean millions of dollars and years of waste.

Get the target market right, and everything else will take care of itself in logical order.

Defining Your Target Customers

The more deeply you can know your target customers the better. The better you'll do at communicating with them, reaching them, marketing and focusing on the right product features and user experience.

This is embodied in your ideal customer profiles and avatars. For internal purposes, the more detailed you are the better.

This may include:

- Job titles
- Incomes
- Education
- Net worth
- Pains and aspirations
- Brand affiliations
- Which communications mediums they use
- What time of day or month they take certain actions
- Favorite colors, fonts, and devices, etc.

Of course, this is a lot of detail. Perhaps pages long for your marketing teams.

When starting out, you probably need to be hyper micro focused on the best customers. It is the best way to make the most of your time and budget and get fast results.

However, when it comes to building a true hypergrowth startup with huge potential you may eventually need to zoom

out as well. Your target may need to be much more broad in order to be inclusive of enough customers.

Your Target Customer Slide

Space and simplicity is your friend. You are going to need to simplify this to just a few bullet points to comfortably fit on this slide. Perhaps along with an image.

However, showing your target customer in a pitch deck really starts well before you get to this slide.

The Market Slide

Here you'll show the total market. The biggest it could be, if you could and wanted to serve them all. Next you'll break it down to your TAM, and SOM. Who you can really reach and serve right now.

The Problem Slide

Through your problem slide you will demonstrate your understanding of the problem you are solving, through your customer. You'll be crisp and clear about the problem. Though also drop in how you've verified and proven this problem with your target customers in a pitch deck.

Solutions & Products Slides

This is a great place to use images to show your product and solution in use in real life situations by your target customers. As they say, a picture is worth a 1,000 words.

The Story

In tandem with your static pitch deck slides, you'll also have a verbal story to tell. It is powerful if you can use this story to depict you as a target customer, them (the investors) as a target

customer, and explain how you ran into the pain, and how they can relate.

Before That

It really all starts with your cover slide. The company name, your business address, contact information, branding, logo, and tagline all show the vibe you are creating, and the type of customer it is made for too. Make sure you've thought through this alignment in advance.

Chapter 13

How to capture the market size in a pitch deck

What's the best way to capture market size in your pitch deck when fundraising?

Market size is one of the most important data points in your pitch deck. This metric alone and how it is presented can be incredibly pivotal when it comes down to getting funded or not. Yet, this remains one number and pitch deck slide that even the most talented and intelligent entrepreneurs and startup founders struggle with. So, how do you find it out and capture the market size in a pitch deck the best possible way?

Presenting Market Size In Your Pitch Deck

One of the top three decision factors investors look at when considering putting capital into a startup is market size. It will make or break you.

You cannot afford to underestimate the importance of this number. The other two main factors are most likely, the founding team and your startup idea. There's only so much you can change about these to elements. However, there is a lot you can do to present market size well, and ensure it gives you the best chance of getting funded.

Done well, you shouldn't have to spend much time on talking around market size during your pitch presentations. Present the metrics as facts, and move on.

There are three ways to present market size in your pitch deck

when fundraising.

They are:

1. Value theory: Predicting buyers willingness to pay
2. Bottom up: Showing existing in-house data
3. Top down: Based on industry research

Use a graphic, clearly and simply laying out the three main metrics in market size:

1. Total market size
2. Total addressable market (TAM)
3. Serviceable and available market (SAM)

Where Market Size Fits In Your Pitch Deck

In this breakdown of the 16 most important slides in your pitch deck, I put the market size slide very close to the beginning, right between The Solution and Competition.

1. Cover
2. Problem
3. Solution
4. Market Size
5. Competition
6. Competitive Advantage
7. Product
8. Traction
9. Customers and Engagement
10. Business Model
11. Financials
12. Amount Being Raised and Other Investors
13. Use of Funds
14. Team
15. Advisors
16. Back Cover

Capturing Market Size In A Pitch Deck: The Musts

There are two musts when it comes to market size and getting funded by serious investors.

1. It's got to be big enough

Your market size should be at least $1B. Probably more. It's what's expected. Your company may never sell for that much, but it shows the potential. More importantly, it demonstrates the potential returns to investors.

2. It has to be realistic

Don't be overly conservative. You've got to sell the dream and potential. For you that may be the mission and product. Hopefully your investors have an affinity for that too. Though they are coming into this presentation for the money. Still, if you aren't realistic with your numbers it is an instant red flag that you either have no idea what you are doing, or you are just fluffing the numbers. You can bet that professional investors who have the kind of money you want have a good sense of when you are undercutting yourself or making things up.

Keep your slide clean. Back up your figures with sources in the appendix.

Total Market Size

How big is this space?

What is the total annual transaction volume and dollar value? Is your business local, regional, national, international or even inter-planetary?

What is the direction and future size of this market? What is the projected annual growth rate?

Total Addressable Market

Your TAM is a portion of the total market. There are few real monopolies. Your product or service probably isn't the perfect fit for everyone in this market. That even applies to Apple and Google.

For example, if your startup focuses on vacation homes, that only relates to a small portion of total annual real estate sales or rentals.

Serviceable & Addressable Market

Also sometimes used interchangeably with SOM (Serviceable and Obtainable Market). This is the percentage of market share you can realistically expect to capture.

Most VCs believe 1-5% is a good range. Remember, you don't need the whole market or even a majority market share to have a billion dollar company in a really big industry. In contrast, if this is a smaller industry, you may need a much larger market share to deliver the returns investors are seeking.

Greenfields: When There Is No Existing Market

Some startups are creating completely new industries and markets. Here investors will care most that you can actually sell your product and there are buyers.

Show the results from customer surveys. What are they saying they want? Show sales. Even if it is only a handful of enterprise level customers, who has actually proven your theory by paying money for what you are offering?

Get A Second Opinion

It always pays to get a second opinion and another pair of experienced eyes on your deck, and especially this slide and

its relevant data. This is even more important if you are new to this industry. You could be missing out on a big chunk of potential market share of size of the market. You may not be thinking like those who know the industry and are most likely to invest.

Consult a fundraising expert to ensure you are maximizing your potential and the success of your deck and pitch.

Chapter 14

How to show your competitor landscape in a pitch deck

How to show your competitor landscape in your pitch deck?

Intelligently displaying your startup's competitor landscape is a critical part of a successful pitch deck and fundraising campaign.

So, what is the best way to show your competition, how you compare, and leverage them into a better business of your own?

How to show your competitor landscape in a pitch deck? Identifying, comparing, and leveraging the competition is critical for effective fundraising

The Importance Of Competition In Your Pitch Deck

Knowing yourself in life and business is very important, but so is knowing your competition.

Your pitch deck is an important document for you, your internal team, hires and consultants. It is often the clearest and most usable document for the direction of your company and business planning. Getting the competitive landscape right here can be pivotal for everything you do.

In startup fundraising, the competition can play a much bigger role than most entrepreneurs can understand. Many go out of their way to deny and downplay competition. That is not the

right strategy. It will hurt your credibility and close doors.

Instead, look at the competitive landscape in your pitch deck as a tool for strategically maximizing urgency, appeal, and value. In many cases this slide is one of the biggest tests investors will put you through.

Here's how to nail it. And, How to show your competitor landscape in your pitch deck?

Who Is Your Competition?

The number one mistake most entrepreneurs make in both starting a business and crafting their pitch decks is overlooking the competition.

If you haven't done your homework on fundraising and your space, and have completed your market research, then the odds of failure are overwhelming. It's just a matter of how much time and money is going to be wasted before going back to start from scratch again.

The second mistake in this respect is denying or believing you don't have competition. The third is trying to hide or dismiss that competition.

If you don't find any active competition in the marketplace now, then a great starting point for any business is to go back and look at previous startup and business attempts in this space. Who else has tried it? Why did they give up? What wasn't working? What did they discover that you may be overlooking? Talk to the founders if you can. They may be more generous at sharing than you expect. Finding out this information can go a long way to help you de-risk your venture and avoid the same pitfalls.

Also, Identify Future Competitor Landscape in a Pitch Deck

Then consider future competitors. If you do start making

progress, get funded and clock some traction, you can be others who want to get in on that money train. Perhaps some are already quietly working on something similar in the lab. Who are they? It could be other brand new startups. Scrappy, fast moving, bootstrapped ventures that may be willing to undercut you and over promise to scoop your market share. Or it will be very big companies who want what you have, and can afford to price you out, sue you out, buy you out, or just out market you.

The other type of competition may be foreign competition in another market or region, who may want to move into your area.

If there are current competitors in this space start building a list and database of them. Who are they? What are they doing well? What are they doing poorly? And, what are they planning? How are they different? Include this information when figuring out how to show your competitor landscape in your pitch deck?

How To Use Your Competitors To Your Advantage In A Pitch Deck

Competition can be a huge advantage when fundraising. Use them to frame and position your business, your investment opportunity, and get investors to take action.

These are three of the top benefits of competition in your deck:

Validation Of Your Startup Idea

Contrary to the popular misconception, having a completely new and unique idea isn't always best. In fact, if you are ahead of your time or it just doesn't have any other foundation, that can be a big disadvantage.

Having competitors means that other people believe in

this idea too. Maybe they have already proven the problem and demand for a solution. Or there may be big and smart companies and investors working on this, validating this is a worthy investment.

Funding Amounts

Competition is great for benchmarking funding asks. For example, you are claiming you are better and have an advantage over a competitor in this space, but they just raised a $9M Seed round from some respectable investors. Well then, shouldn't your company be worth more? Shouldn't you be able to justify at least a $10M or larger seed round?

Exit Strategy & Potential

If larger companies are entering or investing in this space, then that could be a sign there is a good M&A exit on the horizon. It may just be cheaper for them to acquire you. Or for a competitor to roll you up for an even larger public or private exit.

Your Competitive Advantage

Competition is fine, as long as you are clear about your competitive advantage. What is it that you do better? What is the one thing you can keep excelling at over the rest of the pack?

Use your SWOT analysis for clarity on this, and for developing a very strong USP.

The Competitor Landscape Slide

In a pitch deck, the competitor landscape is typically best shown in an image or graph, with your company up and to the right.

Choose your points of reference to plot out how you stand out from your top four or five most serious competitors.

These factors also come into play as you show alignment with this slide through your solution, product, marketing and competitive advantage slide, and even team slide.

Keep Updating It

Your #1 focus should be on your own business and customers, but keep your eye on your competition, keep updating this slide as you go through your rounds and plan your next milestones. And, when putting together a fundraising strategy, work out how to show your competitor landscape in your pitch deck?

Chapter 15

What is the marketing strategy in a pitch deck

What is the place of marketing strategy in your pitch deck when raising money for your startup?

Pitch decks can make or break your startup, and the ability to get the funds you need to launch and grow. Some of the funds you may need so desperately may be to execute on your marketing strategy.

So, what role does this factor play in your deck? What are some smart practices to use, and terrible blunders to avoid?

The Importance Of the Advertising Strategy In A Pitch Deck

Your whole pitch deck and pitch presentation is a marketing exercise. Perhaps one of the most important marketing efforts and sales pitches you will deliver in the life of your startup. Without a good one you may have no marketing capital at all. You may find it very hard to recruit great talent and advisors in addition to investors.

You've got to do great here, and demonstrate how you are going to get customers and sales, so that you can deliver for your investors. If you can't, how can they believe you'll do good in business?

The Problem

The marketing strategy in a pitch deck really starts with your

cover slide and tagline. It becomes even more important on your problem slide. You have to show that you really understand the problem, and have chosen a good one.

In your verbal pitch you'll be telling a story around this problem. One that will personally resonate with your audience. One that lets them feel the pain associated with it.

Sales and marketing is all about the problem versus the solution. The pain versus the pleasure you can bring. If you can't nail the problem, the foundation of everything else is flawed.

The Solution

The solution slide in your pitch deck is where you start selling your product. If you can't sell it to your investors, then how can you expect to sell it to anyone else? However, if you can sell it to cynical investors who are looking for reasons to poke holes in your idea and pitch, then selling regular customers may be much easier.

Here you need to demonstrate that you can keep it simple. Focus on the problem and the one solution you excel at providing. In additional slides you may note a couple of key features, differentiating factors and show off prototypes or demos. Or at least screenshots of them.

Market Size

How big is the market for this product? Is it big enough to warrant going after, creating a business around and investing capital in? What data do you have on the size of the customer pool? Is it growing or shrinking?

In your competition slide, you'll show your competitive advantages over others in this space and how you think you can win market share. This is a critical facet of the marketing

strategy in a pitch deck.

Target Market & Target Customers

Who are your target customers exactly? You can't market well, effectively and profitably unless you really deeply know and understand your customers. What is your customer avatar?

What are some of the use cases for your product? You may even demonstrate this with pictures. How many of these customers with this profile have you spoken to already?

Traction

In your traction slide you are showing what you've achieved so far. This includes how many customers you've acquired and sales you've made. This will show that your marketing strategy is working, and you just need to scale it up. Or if it isn't and you've hit a wall.

The Team

For investors, the ability to execute is even more important than your idea and product. Specifically, do you have the best possible team in this industry to execute a good marketing strategy?

What epic marketing experience do they have? What results have they achieved? What are their qualifications?

If you are weak here, then how will you give your investors confidence that you can not just pull this off, but are the best company in this space for them to bet on?

What amazing advisers or CMO and marketing experts are you bringing on board to champion this all important part of the puzzle?

Business Model

The foundation of your business model is how you will acquire customers. That's an essential part of the marketing strategy in a pitch deck. What marketing channels and tactics have you tried already?
How does your sales funnel work? How much is it costing to acquire new customers and sales? What are the returns on this marketing?

Is Marketing A Part Of Your Fundraising Ask?

Will at least some of the funds you are raising for being used for marketing? If you have no experience or tests, what will you try first, and why? Will you be investing in developing a real, custom marketing strategy? Be careful here.

What marketing does your business rely on? Is it all reliant on Google search or paid ads on Facebook or using TikTok? Or is it enterprise sales with a very long sales cycle?

In which case do you have the sales people with connections and financial runway to afford this? Are you planning a heavy upfront investment in marketing, like a physical store or inventory?

Take a step back and look at this marketing strategy in the pitch deck from your investors' perspective. Is it sustainable? Does it offer good unit economics? Does it give you a moat around your business from competitors?

How will you control your marketing effectiveness and costs in the months and years ahead? What can you do that is unique, and has a high marketing ROI?

What is the marketing strategy in a pitch deck designed for raising money for your startup? Pitch decks affect your ability to get the funds you need to launch and grow

Chapter 16

How to share your traction in a pitch deck

How to share your traction in a pitch deck? In other words, what is the best way to demonstrate traction in your pitch deck?

Showing traction is one of the key elements in startup fundraising. So, what are investors looking for? What is the best way to display it in your deck? If you are coming up short, how do you boost your velocity?

How to share your traction in a pitch deck which is one of the key elements in startup fundraising? Displaying your traction ot boosting velocity is critical

So, what are investors looking for? What is the best way to display it in your deck? If you are coming up short, how do you boost your velocity?

Top Triggers For Getting Your Startup Funded

The business idea is probably actually one of the least impactful factors when it comes to getting your startup funded. Experienced repeat founders and investors know that these factors can really be far more indicative of future success, fundability at future rounds, and longevity.

The Team

Do you have a strong team? Not just a smart team with

degrees from well known universities, but team members who are right for this project, have good and well-rounded business acumen, and the serious grit it is going to take to keep marching through all of the daily challenges? Everything else may change, but if you have the right team, something will work out in the end.

Focus

IQ, deep technical experience, big vision and creativity, and hustle can all yield zero tangible results without focus. You have to be dialed in and have the blinders on to really move the needle and stay headed in the right direction.

The pitch deck is a significant test of focus. 99% of entrepreneurs fail right here. Can you resist all the temptations, and produce a short, clean, simple and focused pitch deck? If not, they probably don't even need to swipe to the traction slide, because you aren't going to get enough.

The Problem

The problem you are setting out to solve is far more important than your intended solution and product or business model. Pick the right problem and demonstrate you have supreme clarity on it, and you'll have a solid foundation for generating traction.

Traction

While all of the above is vitally important, traction will make or break you. Not just in terms of getting funding, but in running your business.

The Big Deal About Traction

What's so important about traction? Why is it such a big deal?

Aside from setting the right foundation for your venture to grow, traction should probably be your biggest focus internally as well.

Firstly, gaining traction shows proof of your concept and demand for a solution to the problem you are working on. After all, investors are pitched with all kinds of fantastic sounding ideas, and slick decks, and sales lines all day long, every day.

The only one way to really differentiate the 90% that will never be more than hype and an idea, and the ones that will actually work is results.

Traction shows that you are really capable of executing and creating meaningful progress. There's not much that beats that.

Your traction also indicates how fast you can grow your business. While growth is never a consistent straight line on its own, your traction can be a strong signal of the multiples that may be possible for investors and how fast they may expect a return on their investment.

What Is Traction?

Traction is progress and growth.

There is more than one way to share your traction in a pitch deck, depending on your startup, focus and what you have to work with.

Examples of this may include:

- Customer acquisition
- Sales volume
- Revenues
- Revenue per employee
- Headcount

How To Project Your Traction In A Pitch Deck

To share your traction in a pitch deck focus on just one metric. Use that to track, display, focus on growing and as the metric of success before the next milestone, and asking for more funds.

Display this prominently on your dedicated traction slide. This is typically done in graph form.

You can also drive this home by showing your growth in this traction metric on your timeline.

How Much Traction Is Enough?

How much traction is enough to show?

Different types of investors at different stages in your startup will have varying expectations of speed of traction.

In the earliest stages investors will be expecting you to show week over week growth. Then that may expand to month over month, and later, year over year.

Eventually growth will slow once you get big. In the early days you may be up against other startups growing 10% or more per week or month, and at least 50% per year.

Questions To Expect On Your Traction

After presenting your pitch deck you are going to be fielding questions from investors. Acing these questions is going to greatly determine whether you get the funds or not.

Obviously, a great, clean pitch deck is very lean, so some of the follow up questions you should be prepared for on your traction will probably include:

- How well are you retaining customers?
- Sales from new versus existing customers?
- Percentage of refunds given?
- How are your reviews?
- Forecasts for traction over the next year?
- Profit margins on this traction?

Ways To Boost Traction

- Join a startup accelerator or incubator
- Partner up for distribution and sales
- Get scrappy with your marketing
- Leverage affiliates, franchisees, or influencers
- Publish more content
- Make sure your team is refocused on this traction metric

Summary

Traction is one of the most important factors for getting your startup funded. It's one tangible proof point that can differentiate you from all the hyped up sales pitches with no results. Hone in on it, and excel here to get the financial fuel your venture needs. Learn how to share your traction in a pitch deck carefully and you're sure to acquire all the funding you need.

Chapter 17

How to position the team in a pitch deck

How you present and position your team in your pitch deck can make all the difference in getting your startup funded. So, how do you introduce your team well? Who is even on your 'team' when it comes to designing your pitch deck? What do investors want to see? How can you fill in the gaps?

The Most Important Slide In Your Pitch Deck

What is the most important slide in your pitch deck?

Some think it is the solution? Others the problem slide? The financials slide is a popular one with investors. The cover slide can be key to setting up the entire deck with a great first impression.

Yet, it is the team slide which really trumps all the others in importance.

Yes, you have to get the others right. Though the decision to fund you or not often all comes down to the team.

You can have the right problem, solution, a great product idea and be in a really big market, but without a team investors are willing to bet on, they aren't going to give up a dime. Ironically, the opposite can almost be true in some cases.

What Investors Are Looking For In A Fundable Team

If the team is so important, what is it that potential investors really want to see?

There are two main factors that they are looking at:

1. Ability
2. Commitment

Is your team capable?

There are two parts to this. First is if your team has the technical ability to solve this problem. What unique skills have you developed to understand and solve this problem? Maybe you are one of only a few engineers or scientists in the world to have spent years studying and working on systems like these.

The second part is real experience, especially in a business context. Being able to code, design a system, or having seen many others do it is one thing. Having the commercial experience of creating a product that sells, and building a profitable business that can scale is a completely different thing. It's apples to oranges or ice cream to cake.

Technical genius is one thing, but it doesn't make an actual business. So, you also want experience in marketing, managing a team, finance, and more. If you have experience in a startup setting, and especially have previous exits with strong multiples returned to investors that is a huge bonus.

Investors are looking for the best team. That's the one you'd back with your own money, right? It is the startup with the best team that wins. So, demonstrating that you've compiled the best team with experience in your domain can help overcome weaknesses in any other area.

Being coachable is also a huge deal. Being intelligent and wise is important. Though being coachable can be far more important than what you know. There will always be things

you don't know. You'll never get it if you aren't willing to learn from those who do have the experience.

How can you prove you won't quit?

Everything else can look perfect, but without the grit and perseverance no entrepreneur or team is going to survive the constant barrage of daily challenges that are going to come.

What can you demonstrate that shows you have commitment and resilience? What have you done in the past that shows you've got what it takes? What have you sacrificed to get here? What are you willing to give up to continue with this startup and get this funding?

Who Counts As Your Team In Your Pitch Deck?

You only have a limited amount of space to display your team on a pitch deck slide. There are also downsides to including too many team members. Even though they may be key team members, if they are just employees there is the risk they may not stick it out. That's not going to look awesome, if you are bleeding people who you raised money based on having during the funding process.

So, what we are specifically talking about here are:

- Coufounders
- Executives
- Advisors

When To Start Introducing The Team In Your Pitch

The team slide typically comes in late in the pitch deck. Though you don't have to wait that long to begin positioning your team. Begin introducing your team and positioning them with these qualities early on. You can do it with your verbal introduction, the story of your problem and solution, and so on.

You should also try to bring in your cofounders to any live pitches or on video calls.

What To Include On Your Team Slide

The team slide is simple. It is profile pictures of your team, their names and roles, and a one or two sentence bio. Just a few words which best sums up how they bring the above strengths to the table.

You can also include links to their executive bios on your website (best), or links to their LinkedIn profiles for more depth.

You may include a second slide for notable advisors as well.

What If Your Team Could Be Stronger?

If you aren't confident that your current team checks all the boxes, this is the time to do something about it.

You can:

- Hire the best in the business
- Bring in cofounders who are willing to bring capital
- Give small amounts of equity to notable advisors to bring them in

As a part of your fundraising ask you can also explain who you will hire to fill any of these gaps with the funds you bring in

Chapter 18

How to present the amount to raise in a pitch deck

Creating a pitch deck is really all about getting funded and asking for the money. There is a lot of advice available on pitch deck design, and many of the core slides in a deck. Though much less on presenting the raise and ask. So, how do you position your ask?

How Much Should You Be Raising?

Before you ask, you have to know how much to ask for. Sooner or later you are going to have to justify that number somehow too.

From the headlines it may seem like many startups are raising at very arbitrary numbers. There are good reasons to round up. Yet, any investor who has put in the work and sacrifice and has had the financial wisdom to amass the amount of capital you are asking for is going to obviously have some financial smarts, and will want to do the math. If they have other investors or LPs they are responsible to, then they are legally liable for making sure the math makes sense too.

So, what should your raise be based on?

Reaching The Next Milestone

Exactly what the need is will vary by your fundraising round. Whichever stage that is, this pitch deck is all about getting you to the next milestone.

This may be building a prototype, getting to market, scaling and expanding, or funding the roll up of other companies ahead of an exit.

There may be hard fixed costs to get there and investments to be made.

Runway

Not only may you have to layout capital investments to get to the next milestone, but you will have carrying costs and operating expenses to keep running until you get there as well. This can include software, leased space, communications, insurances, payroll, etc.

The average time between funding rounds has typically been about 12 to 18 months. In times of crisis and great financial uncertainty the ability to close a new round may be delayed. Meaning raising for a longer runway is wise. While you may be able to raise back to back rounds faster, it is dangerous to bet on it.

Make sure you are raising enough to get through closing the next fundraising round, without getting so low on capital that your next investors can have the power to take advantage of you.

Hiring

Expanding hiring is considered a good use of funds if it is justified by need. After all, having the best team in your space is critical for winning. Sharing your hiring needs in your deck can also lead to introductions to top talent from your investors.

Comps

How much are your competitors raising at this stage in business? That is a good justification and benchmark to use.

Cushion

Be sure to include additional funds for a cushion. Everything costs more than you think, and takes longer than you think. It's far better to have extra, than not enough.

The Ask Slide

Keep your ask slide extremely simple. All you need is a few bullet points laying out the categories you plan to use funds for.

Be wary of asking for money for marketing channels that don't seem efficient, or asking for less than competitors have been raising at for the same rounds.

Positioning The Ask

Setting up the ask is done throughout your previous slides.

The Financials Slide

The financials slide demonstrates the potential returns on their investment in a simple way. Early stage startups have very simple, if any existing financials. So, it is about crisply laying out the forecast and projections for profit margins and growth.

The Problem Slide

The core of your business isn't really the product or solution, it is the problem. If you have the right and a strong problem, everything will work itself out. Use your problem slide to show you have clarity on the problem. An urgent one, with demand, that you have proven exists, and you understand the value of in terms of what solving it is worth to your target customers.

Market Slide

Use this slide to show just how big this market and potential business is. How vast can their investment grow as you expand into this market and the problem grows over the next decade?

Traction Slide

If you have proven the problem, and have created a solution and product, how is that showing up through actually doing business? This is where you give them something tangible. It's real. Something that they can take to the bank, instead of only being an inspiring dream. How many sales have you been making? What about revenues and profits and unit economics? If they add their capital how can it simply multiply the great results you are getting already?

Other Investors

What other investors have participated in previous rounds that can give you credibility and make them feel smart about participating in? Which other investors have committed to participating in this round? Which investor has committed to leading this round and can make them feel comfortable and confident about jumping in too? How much are these other investors pledging to put in?

Summary

There is a lot of art to creating a successful pitch deck. When it comes to presenting your ask, you have to be able to back up the math. Your positioning of the ask should start well before the ask slide, and allow them to connect the dots for themselves.

Chapter 19

How to nail your pitch deck narrative

How to nail your pitch deck's narrative?

Having the right facts and data points is good. Everyone has that covered. How you present the narrative in your pitch deck can be far more pivotal.

How do you nail this vital part of the mission when getting ready to pitch investors who can help bring your vision to becoming reality?

A Great Startup Is Built On…

What is the key to building a successful startup? Is it the business idea? The market size? The IP you've registered?

These things can all help. Though it is really all about the narrative. The story that it told.

This is true of your startup as a whole. It makes all the difference in individual sales and securing sizable distribution channels. It is true for getting the best team to buy into the mission. For achieving the best M&A outcomes, and certainly for fundraising.

If you start digging into it you'll quickly find that the real value is all found, unlocked, and created by the story. So, how do you unfold a great one in your pitch deck and presentation

so that you not only maximize all of these other parts of your business, but your fundraising efforts too?
Find the Best Story for Your Pitch Deck

You do have a story. Your startup has a story. There is a great one hiding in there. Use it as a starting point when thinking about how to nail your pitch deck's narrative?

However, many entrepreneurs, especially technically minded founders either have a hard time seeing it, are afraid to tell it, or they try to replace it with lots of facts and stats and technical specs. Because that's how their minds work. Though it is not what sells a startup or an investment opportunity.

Remember, at least for now you are pitching humans, not algorithms. Maybe soon, just like replicating hit songs, computers will be able to identify hit stories, it's just not coming in time for this startup, for the next couple of funding rounds.

So your story not only needs to be unique and compelling, but personal.

If you can't see it, or the story you are telling isn't working as well as you hoped, then considering bringing in an expert storyteller who does this for a living. Have a conversation with them. Let them extract your best story and spin it in the best possible way.

The Characters

Who is this band of characters in your story?

Every great story, book, movie and startup has a great cast of characters. Think Lord of the Rings, The Fantastic Four or the PayPal Mafia. Who are yours?

Who are the heroes on the journey? Who else will be a part of

their journey and can also play a notable role, like the wizard in the Wizard of Oz? This covers your founders, advisors and investors.

Then you have your customers and employees. They are all telling themselves a story too. They want to participate in a great story. Like buying the latest iPhone, even if it is ridiculously overpriced, unnecessary, and offers little tangible improvement over the current phone.

Or buying a $500 bottle of Tesla tequila. Or being a part of a world changing that can stop climate change. Think about how you can include them when figuring out how to nail your pitch deck's narrative?

These are parts of the story that will show up on your cover slide, team slide, competitive advantage and product slides.

Your team slide also describes how life has prepared you for this moment and to be the one to champion this problem and bring the solution.

Your Why

Your why can be the most important anchor of your story. It can be the most compelling part of the story that convinces others to come along for the ride. It also gives investors confidence that you will stick with this venture through all of the daily challenges. This is the big differentiating factor in startups and entrepreneurs that win. Even more so than the idea and product.

This will probably show up in the problem slide. Be sure to explain why you are driven to solve this problem. How did you encounter it? What examples can you give investors of how they've encountered it and have felt this pain before.

How Are You Going To Be The Champions Of This Story?

What is the solution you are bringing that will make you the champions of this story and give you victory over the bad guys? What is the superpower you are bringing to the table?

If there are pieces missing, what are they? What will you need to find or navigate to complete the journey? That's a good starting point when designing ideas for how to nail your pitch deck's narrative?

Paint Your Vision Of The Future with a Great Pitch Deck Story

Where the real art of storytelling and fundraising come together is in forecasting your vision of the future. What does the future look like when your startup is really being successful? What does success look like for them? You have to sell the dream. Some of that will be data based. Yet, it also takes some art.

Summary

Being technical may be the key to many things in a startup. Including developing a great product and IP, maintaining good unit economics, and establishing a technological competitive advantage. Yet, it is storytelling that unveils and adds the most value. The best narrative wins. Not the best product or most qualified and capable team. If you want the funds and all of the advantages that come with that, get a great story. Just make sure you can back it up with facts too.

How to nail your pitch deck's narrative? Having the right facts and data points is good but presenting the narrative in your pitch deck can be far more pivotal.

How do you nail this vital part of the mission when getting ready to pitch investors who can help bring your vision to becoming reality?

Chapter 20

How to present your pitch deck to investors

How do you start successfully presenting your pitch deck to potential investors?

Investors play a significant role in the startup ecosystem. For plenty of entrepreneurs raising money from investors is what getting into startups is all about. In many cases raising money from investors is a must for getting a startup off the ground, if not just empowering it to reach its maximum potential.

So, how do you go about getting in front of investors who can give your startup the funding it needs?

Why Are You Raising Money?

Before you start reaching out to investors, it is important to get clarity on why you are raising funds.

Just as much as you need to be clear on your why for starting your business, you probably aren't going to get the end results you want from raising money and pitching investors, unless you are clear on your why here too.

Even if your only why is just to get as much money as possible, you need to be hitting the right investors at the right time, with the right presentation.

If you are raising to build a prototype or hardware, there

will be certain investors for that. If you are raising to test and prove your product, then there may be other investors for that. If you've already proven product market fit, then there are different sets of investors who can help you scale and open other doors for you.

Be sure you understand the advantages and disadvantages of raising at each stage, and who is the right fit, or you'll be giving away significant chunks of your company and control, without really being able to put that money to its best use.

Who Are The Right Investors?

The first step to honing in on who to present your pitch deck to is identifying the right investors for your stage. While the lines can blur at the edges, these are generally the steps you will take through different fundraising rounds. At least unless you really bootstrap for an extended period, and through key milestones.

Friends & Family

To get off the ground, work through the idea and have something to show you'll be starting off with raising money through your personal network. Family and friends, friends of family, and family of friends. Think old classmates, professors, bosses and coworkers.

Angel Investors & Startup Accelerators

The next step is professional angel investors, angel groups and startup accelerators and incubators which also provide seed stage funding.

Venture Capital Firms

Series A, B and C rounds bring the need for bigger checks to perfect and start scaling startups. This is the main space that

VCs occupy.

Private Equity Funds & Strategic Corporate Investors

Series D, E and F rounds have become increasingly popular as startups choose to stay private and grow for longer on their own. Often these rounds fund global expansion and the roll up of other companies in their space prior to going public or an even larger M&A deal.

Making A Shortlist

There should always be more to partnering with investors than the money. In fact, the money should probably be the last thing on your list.

Even if all you want to accomplish is to raise the most possible money over the next couple of years, and sell your company for billions of dollars, you also need the best investment partners to help you unlock and make the next steps possible.

So, what are the other resources you should be looking for in an investor?

- Experienced operational advisors
- Introductions to other investors
- Recruiting help for key team members and executives
- Distribution and supplier channels

You've probably heard of other startup entrepreneurs who have had to present their pitch decks to hundreds of investors before getting a single yes. That's a lot of time and energy. All of which could be spent actually building a business. You can dramatically reduce the odds of being told no and having to go through so many presentations by honing in even further.

- Which investors have been investing in startups like yours?

- Who believes in your mission and vision?
- Who has a good reputation for treating founders and customers well?
- Which investors are working on a similar exit timeline as you?

Polishing Your Pitch Deck

The pitch deck is the core of presenting your investment opportunity. That is no doubt even truer today in the post COVID lockdown world we live in. Now that you've got a tight shortlist of investors to present to, make sure you go back and polish your pitch deck and be sure it is a great fit for them.

Keep it short and simple. 10 to 16 slides is plenty. Use a proven existing template to work efficiently.

In addition to your pitch deck, plan on being prepared with key supporting materials, including:

- One page business plan
- Executive summary
- Your latest investor update

Presenting Your Pitch Deck

Often you'll be sending your deck in advance to even get noticed or get a conversation with investors.

You can do that by email attachment or sending a link to a shared Google Drive folder with these documents.

When you do get to present in person, whether live in front of a large audience, in a private meeting, or over Googe Meet, you need a strong 15 to 20 minute verbal presentation to go with your slides. Then you need to be well prepared to successfully navigate a grilling in the Q&A session.

Chapter 21

How to send a pitch deck to friends and family

How do you send your pitch deck to friends and family?

Friends and family will be an incredibly pivotal part of your journey as an entrepreneur. This is true whether you actually directly raise money from them or not. If you can raise from them, it can be some of the best capital you can bring in. Here's how to approach it.

Pitching Friends & Family

There are three reasons to pitch and send a pitch deck to friends and family:

1. For practice ahead of pitching angels or VCs
2. For raising from from them before going onto other rounds
3. For gaining introductions to their friends and family who may fund you

Even if you don't raise from them, this is your core support group. Entrepreneurship can be lonely. You are really going to appreciate having them in your corner on this journey. For them to do that it really helps for them to get what you are doing, get excited about it, and understand some of your challenges.

Just practicing with them can really help you find holes in your

pitch, polish it and perfect it, before approaching the investors you really want.

You may also be surprised at what introductions they can make for you too. The network around this group is hundreds and thousands of people. They may be able to open many doors for you, far beyond just the money.

The Place Of The Friends & Family Round

When it comes to the series of fundraising rounds the friends and family round comes first. This is typically your pre-seed round.

If your family is well off, then they may have the financial capacity to participate in your Seed as well. The majority don't.

Whatever their level of participation, official or not, raising money from friends and family is significant to future investors. It shows that others believe in you, your mission and business. It shows that those who know you best really believe in you. You can imagine the opposite is true too.

Who Are Friends & Family?

Who counts as friends and family?

- Immediate and extended family members
- Coworkers and former coworkers and bosses
- College classmates and professors
- Strong social media connections
- Friends of friends, family of friends, and friends of family

The Pros & Cons Of Raising From Friends And Family

There are both potential pros and cons to raising from friends and family.

The most obvious advantage of raising from this group is that it can be the fastest and easiest money you can raise. They should already know you, like you and trust you, and that is 90% of the battle.

In many cases this group may also be the most lenient when things aren't going according to plan. They may be more patient and hands off.

The opposite can also be true, and that can be one of the biggest cons of raising from this group as well. If the business isn't going well then these relationships can be strained. Your business is important to you, but these relationships can be even more valuable.

If these raises are messy, they can complicate ownership structures and make future raises more complicated and expensive than they need to be.

Curating Your Pitch Deck For Friends & Family Rounds

If you are serious about raising from this group of potential investors then it is worth curating your pitch deck for them.

Consider what may be most important for them to learn, and less so. Since you already have a personal relationship with them, or at least a very warm introduction, this is much less about proving your individual capability, and even track record or returns, as it is telling a story that resonates with them personally, and selling them on the dream.

How To Share & Send Your Pitch Deck To Friends & Family

If this is a test run for raising from more professional investors then you may want to do a full trial run with how you plan to share your pitch deck with them. That may be via email or Google Drive.

Whenever possible you also want to be presenting this in person as well, just as if you were meeting with any other investor. You may also use a video chat service with screen sharing capability or this. Like Google Meet.

If you want to raise from your friends and family network then it is also smart to reach out using the ways you normally communicate with them. Or at least through the mediums they use most. That may include texting, WhatsApp, or by sending private YouTube or Vimeo slideshow links.

Next Steps

After sharing and presenting, collect and evaluate all the feedback you get. Tweak your pitch deck and presentation as you see fit to optimize it for future pitches.

If you still need to raise from other investors, then get busy building your target list of ideal investors. Then begin repeating sharing and pitching for real this time.

Then it is about getting to work and delivering on the results you promised. Put that money to great use achieving the next milestones you vowed to conquer. Once you do that more capital will open up to you. Your initial investors will want to put in more capital, and they will tell others that you did what you said and were able to execute. Future investors will also now have references to check in within.

Chapter 22

How to send your pitch deck to a venture capital firm

How do you go about successfully sending your startup's pitch deck to a venture capital firm?

VCs play a big role in the startup ecosystem. For many entrepreneurs getting funded by them is like the holy grail. For some it seems to be the whole motivation for coming up with a startup idea in the first place. In a lot of cases venture capital is essential for getting a startup off the ground, if not at least helping it realize its full potential.

So, how do you go about sending your pitch deck to a VC firm for funding?

Venture Capital's Role In Startup Fundraising

VCs are probably the most visible and famous funding sources in this space.

They are not the only sources of financing though. There is private equity and strategic corporate investors. Angel investors and angel groups may even be more plentiful and provide more overall dollar funding for startups. Then there are a variety of banks and commercial lenders who provide debt financing as well.

Venture Capital firms usually come into the picture from Series A to Series C fundraising rounds. This is evolving, and they may invest earlier or later as well. Though the first

funding usually comes from friends and family or angels and crowdfunding. With the latest rounds coming from PE and strategics. Often leading to M&A deals.

Start With Why

Before rushing to blast out a pitch deck or present in front of venture capital firms, make sure you really own your why.

Firstly, why raise money at all?

Do you absolutely need to raise money in the form of equity capital to get your business off the ground? Is it really hugely advantageous to raise capital at this stage in business?

It can be, but make sure you are doing it at the right time, for the right reasons. If you are not, then giving up large percentages of your company, without the most efficient uses of that capital can also be destructive.

Be sure to weigh the pros and cons of bootstrapping versus raising, before just leaping because you think it is the status quo.

If raising is the right move, then why VCs?

Are you at the right stage for VC firms? If so, then what do you really want from them aside from money? Some highly successful repeat founders bring in VCs, even when they don't need the capital. Money can actually be the worst reason to go fundraising. Even if you do just need the money, then what other benefits can you be looking for?

Investors can add a lot of extra value, and you should get as much as you can for what you are giving up in equity and ownership rights. That may include recruiting help, connections, distribution channels, other investor introductions, advisors and board members that will give you

more credibility and operating strength.

Know Your Who

While the top 50 venture capital firms are probably responsible for more than 80% of all the VC dollars invested each year, there may be well over 1,000 firms to choose from for pitching.

It is unfortunately not uncommon for startup entrepreneurs to end up pitching hundreds of investors before getting their first yes. Often even going to countless meetings and multiple meetings with some VCs before getting told no.

If you are spending half of your time each week just on fundraising efforts for months or a year, you can imagine the huge drain, and time that could be used actually building a successful business.

Taking the time in advance to do your research and make a much tighter short list of your ideal investors should yield a far more efficient fundraising experience.

This shortlist should be composed of your ideal and best fitting investors. Those who have the most to offer in additional resources and credibility, as well as who are experts in your space, are actively funding your type of startup, believe in your vision and have alignment with your timeline.

Once you've got your shortlist of VCs, be sure you polish your pitch deck, and curate and tailor it to fit them best.

How To Send Your Deck To Venture Capital Firms

Connecting With VCs

The first step is to connect with your target VC firms and partners. This may include:

- Sending cold emails
- Reaching out via DMs on social media networks
- Asking for introductions
- Using consultants and advisors with connections
- Attending pitch events
- Joining a startup incubator or accelerator
- In person networking

Sharing The Deck

You are probably either going to email the pitch deck as an attachment, or provide a private link for access online, like in Google Drive.

You'll also accompany your pitch deck with supporting materials, like:

- Your latest investor update
- Executive summary
- One page business plan

When emailing cold connections, pay special attention to the from address you are emailing from, your subject line, and the body. You've got to stand out and motivate them to view it.

What's Next?

Follow up. Don't be afraid to follow up. Make sure they received and made time to view it. You can also use yoru investor updates to add that extra sense of urgency.

Get prepared for investor meetings. Whether in person or via Google Meet, be ready, be in the right mindset, and be ready for the questions you'll be hit with.

Chapter 23

How to share a pitch deck securely

To share a pitch deck securely, you must use software services with robust cybersecurity. This software preferably includes some form of encryption with end to end encryption, which is the safest way to protect your pitch.

In this article, I'm going to show you why the security of your pitch deck is important and how to share your pitch deck securely. In this way, you can ensure your pitch does not fall into the wrong hands.

Why Pitch Deck Security is Important

The shadowy world of espionage and sabotage doesn't belong just in the pages of a James Bond novel; for a serious businessperson with a real business plan, they are both real dangers. Whenever money is involved, especially around innovative products or services with unique selling points, stealing is sadly something we have to guard against.

Think about putting together your beautiful idea for a new product/service, amassing hundreds of hours of product development and market research time, only to have someone take your idea and sell it as their own.

Let me put this simply: This happens every day!

There are several ways to protect yourself against this, including product patents and trademarks.

However, copyright will only protect you and your business to a degree. Patents stop people from copying your idea outright, but another company could draw influence from your concept and create something that is different enough. Your competitors' ideas could blow you out of the water, but not violate copyright.

This is especially true for large companies who can throw money and resources at a product in a way that most entrepreneurs cannot. Even if you have a head start, those with such resources can make it to market first.

Pitch deck security helps to alleviate at least some of the risk. When you're pitching your idea to angel investors, especially if you aren't already trading, you want to limit pitch exposure so you can control who sees it and who does not.

The problem is that robust security is required to do this.

Who Should See Your Pitch Deck?

It's important to have a clear idea of who you want to give access to your ideal pitch deck. When you know this, everyone else outside of this group should be kept in the dark.

There are two categories of people who you should want to see your pitch deck. I label these categories "investment" and "networking".

The investment category includes anyone who has the potential to invest in your business idea and help you take it forward. The networking category involves anyone who can get your pitch to those potential investors.

You could send your pitch directly to an investor in the investment category. But, you could also send it to someone you know with good business contacts and they could forward it on for you. Obviously, there's a bigger security risk if there is

a third party between you and the investor, but sometimes this is unavoidable.

It's good if you know you can trust others with your ideas and business concepts, but unfortunately, you must still be vigilant – especially if your idea is potentially worth millions!

Who Shouldn't See Your Pitch?

Retrict your pitch deck to those who need to know only. Anyone outside of this is superfluous. Sometimes you might share your deck for feedback, but try to do this with trusted parties only.

Most of all, do your best to ensure that competitors will not get their hands on your pitch deck. An existing competitor could potentially get your product to market before you. Or, at least develop some concept that solves the same problem for consumers, rendering your offering pointless.

This is where learning how to share a pitch deck during the startup fundraising process securely comes into play. You can minimize all of these issues with some good security practices

Keep Everything Secure

The first thing you should do is ensure that any computer device (tablet, laptop, smartphone, etc.) that stores a copy of your pitch deck, is secure. This means good anti-virus software, but also a solid firewall.

If your business has its own premises or operates on a large network, it needs to have good cybersecurity. If your budget allows for it, you can hire someone in IT with a background in cybersecurity to ensure your data is protected. Alternatively, you can buy commercial licenses for good cybersecurity software (McAfee, Avira, Zoho, etc.) and install it yourself.

If you have a much larger budget, get the assistance of companies like IBM that offer powerful business-wide cybersecurity.

Options for Sharing Your Pitch Deck Securely

Okay, now you have your cybersecurity sorted, let's talk about how to share your pitch deck securely. There are many ways to do this, and they essentially come down to two approaches: Digital Vs. Paper.

In the 21st century, digital tools are better than other options for the most part, but paper copies of your pitch deck can't be hacked. They can even be printed on Security Paper. This type of paper cannot be easily copied. It can also be watermarked uniquely for each copy of your deck. That way if your deck is copied, you know who copied it.

If you are going to send paper copies to potential investors, remember that you'll need a trusted courier. But, you do not to be too disheartened if investors prefer digital copies for ease.

If you are using a digital option, you could use a service like Google Docs. There, you can set the access levels for any document, only allowing specific people to access it. You can also set the security level for interaction. This means that you could allow a user to view a document, but not download or edit it.

Alternatively, you could send your documents via end to end encryption. There are services like Send Safely, that allow you to do just that. A cheaper, though the less secure option, is to use a social media messaging app with end to end encryption. However, this seems less professional.

Sending your pitch by email is also an option, though this is usually less secure.

Chapter 24

What do I need other than a pitch deck

What do you need besides a pitch deck to launch and fund a successful startup?

A great pitch deck may be the most crucial tool in effectively launching, building and financing a startup business. Yet, it is not the only thing you need.

Here are some of the other assets you want to have lined up as a founder to ensure your venture has the wings to fly and legs to get funded.

What Else You Need To Start A Startup

Having a strong pitch deck is great. It can be the key to opening the vault to the money you need to get going and grow. It can be a vital document for attracting the right hires and advisors. Then for keeping your entire team (and you) focused on the big vision and the next most important steps.

However, no matter how incredible your deck is, it alone isn't going to do everything for you.

Business, Marketing & Cash Flow Plans

Real business plans aren't as trendy as they used to be. That doesn't mean they aren't an essential ingredient. In fact, recent high profile startup failures may suggest they are more important than ever.

I recently interviewed Joshua Motta of Coalition and Cloudflare on the Dealmakers Podcast. After starting multi-billion dollar ventures, and in spite of being a tech genius who was recruited by Microsoft and the CIA as a teenager, he took time out to create a business plan for his most recent venture. A long form, 70 page written plan. If it was a must for him, it probably has value for those with less experience too.

Two of the other VIP documents at this stage are your marketing plan and budget and cash flow analysis. Without marketing you don't have a business. Without knowing your cash flow needs and how you'll cover them, you are almost guaranteed to go broke like 90% of startups who fail for running out of money.

Mission, Vision & Culture

You need a strong why and mission to stay the course and to bring in the best talent who will be passionate about helping you succeed. You also need to know and be able to paint the big picture vision for everyone. It will keep you going and focused.

More and more hyper successful fast growth startup founders are realizing just how important company culture is too. In fact, it's everything. So, when it comes to creating their second and third successful startups, or having to choose one important piece of advice to share with other first time entrepreneurs it is frequently to start with culture.

Not just a fluffy ideal. But taking the time to be intentional and mindful and to write a values and culture document to hire and operate by. It is probably the very first thing you should document for your next startup company.

Team

Business is a team sport. That's even truer when it comes to

startups. Find a great team to surround yourself with and build this thing together.

This can include cofounders who help lift you up and get you through the tough days. It is key hires with domain experience. It is experienced advisors who have been there and done it before.

Business Formation & Business Bank Accounts

You can't start to bring in cash or funding until you have a business bank account. So, claim your website domain, social handles, tax ID number and incorporate your business. Be sure to get a fundraising or M&A consultant who can help you best structure your equity and stock for raising and growing your business.

Take Action

Don't get too lost in the weeds creating all these assets and documents. You aren't going to get anywhere until you are actually taking bold actions.

What Else You Need To Raise Money

You'll need more than just a pitch deck when it comes to startup fundraising too.

You'll need connections and a network so that you can get to the investors. They can be your own friends and contacts, or you can hack your way there by leveraging those who already have these relationships.

You'll need a sentence or two as an elevator pitch. These are musts for every conversation you have from here on out. You won't build your network or get to present your deck without it.

If you are looking for debt financing instead of equity, then your executive summary will be even more important than your pitch deck.

When it comes to equity fundraising you'll need somewhere to host your deck in the cloud for investors, and to collaborate on it with your teams. You'll need a pitch message to introduce your deck when you send it out. You'll need a phone or live pitch script to carry you through actually presenting and closing investors. You'll need an easy to use CRM for building an investor database, nurturing investor leads and following up with them.

You have to be willing to go all in too. Don't expect investors to throw you all of their money if you aren't all in and aren't willing to make sacrifices too.

Even to get to this point you'll need a lot of grit and resilience. Many of the best funded founders have had to deal with dozens and even hundreds of investor rejections before they finally got a single yes.

Then you have to be able to back it up. It's easy to make promises and claims and to attract potential customers and investors. Just don't get too far ahead of yourself. It will catch up with you fast when they find out you've been fluffing the facts a little too much.

Conclusion

Remember that ultimately fundraising is all about storytelling. Investors are investing for the most part in future and possibility. Even more in the early stage financings.

BONUS: if you need help from A to Z with fundraising you may want to look into Inner Circle which is our fundraising program.

In our fundraising program you will gain access to the following:

- Monthly calls with me and Mike Seversen where we provide training and Q&A on everything related to capital raising efforts
- Over 14 hours of training content on fundraising and financial modeling
- More than 10 templates (pitch deck, due diligence checklist, executive summary, NDA, term sheets, convertible notes, etc) that you could use for your fundraising efforts
- Access to several lists of investors that you could use (VCs, angel groups, angel investors, family offices, etc)
- Private Facebook group where you could network with other founders
- And many more perks!

LEARN MORE ABOUT INNER CIRCLE